CONSUL GUIDE TO
RELATIONSHIPS

Enhance romantic partnerships, friendships, and parent-child relationships

16Personalities

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Introduction

Why Relationships Matter to Consuls

As Extraverts, Consuls love connecting with other people, whether it be a new friend or a close family member. Their social lives often revolve around group gatherings, and they're equally comfortable at a bustling party or a mellow cookout. Group dynamics energize Consuls, so a one-on-one cup of coffee with an old friend may hold less appeal for them than a big reunion.

Consuls find it easy to meet people wherever they go, but they feel especially drawn to connect with others through traditional, respected institutions, such as civic organizations or faith communities. In their free time, they find themselves nurturing these connections and participating in related events, from fundraisers to board meetings. Consuls hate to let people down, making them unlikely to flake on plans that they've made with friends or acquaintances. In return, they firmly expect the people in their lives to be consistent and reliable.

That said, Consuls take care not to let their social responsibilities compromise their family life. Many people with this personality type consider family among their top priorities, so it isn't surprising that Consuls are the most likely personality type to want children. They may even view parenthood as the most important endeavor of their lives, not to mention a meaningful way to carry on the time-honored traditions that they received from their parents.

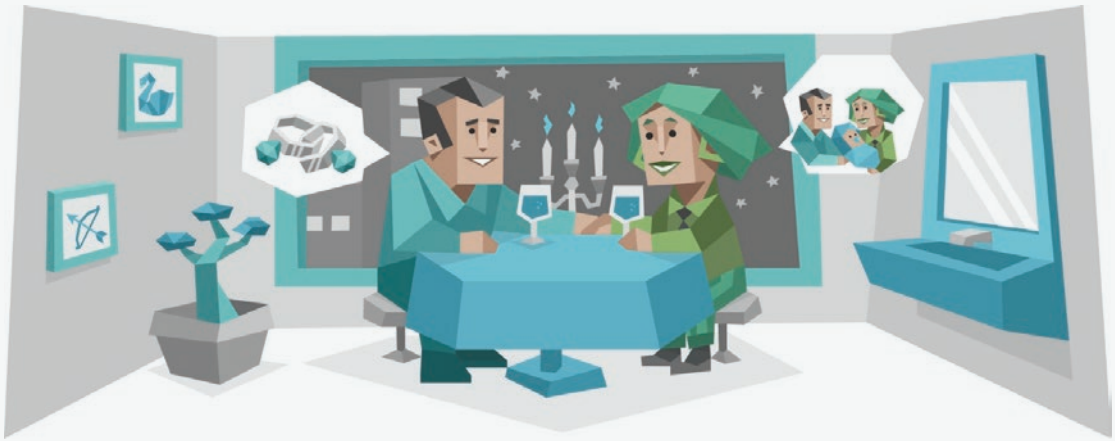
Many Consuls gain a sense of security and personal significance from the presence of their nearest and dearest. This quality can contribute

to their relationships, enabling people with this personality type to feel deeply connected with those they love. When Consuls become dependent on other people for reassurance, however, this characteristic can quickly turn into a weakness. They may become hypersensitive to others' behavior, feeling wounded whenever a loved one seems to pull away, ignore them, or disregard their advice. Consul personality types can become trapped in this unbalanced dynamic, deriving their self-worth from their relationships rather than from within.

Fortunately, Consuls bring many strengths to their relationships, including an incredible sense of warmth. Devoted and attentive, they care deeply about their friends, family, and romantic partners and do everything in their power to ensure their vision of a pleasant and stable life for the people they love.

Curious about the traits that make up your personality type and the theory behind them? You can learn more here.

In these pages, we'll discuss Consuls' gifts at length and how they influence people with this personality type in romance, friendship, and – if they have children – parenthood. We'll also suggest ways that people with this personality type can bring balance to a variety of relationship types and stages. Along the way, Consuls will be equipped with insights and strategies to help them forge the meaningful connections and sense of belonging that they crave.



Romantic Relationships

Devoted and attentive in their relationships, Consuls are willing to make sacrifices to support their partners. Although they might not ask for it directly, Consuls – in their heart of hearts – hope to find someone who will do the same for them. Above all, Consuls long for a partner who shares their values and makes them feel deeply appreciated.

Love brings Consuls a sense of stability, and they may feel more complete when they're in a partnership. Outgoing by nature, people with this personality type connect readily with others, and they may find it easy to meet potential matches and embark on new relationships. Family is a top priority for Consuls, and many are eager to find a life partner with whom to raise children.

It would be a mistake, however, to think of Consuls as needy or desperate. Balanced Consuls wait until they find someone who stands by them, honoring their feelings and opinions without necessarily pandering to them. In return, balanced Consuls offer their partners a loving, stable foundation for their lives together. This includes a strong social foundation, as Consuls excel at establishing themselves and their partners within their communities.

Consuls care a great deal about their relationships, and they aim to notice the nuances of their partners' emotional states. Dedicated and steadfast, Consuls are willing to work hard to make a relationship flourish as long as they feel respected and valued.

That doesn't mean such relationships are invulnerable. They can still succumb to the forces that break couples apart, particularly if Consuls feel criticized or have the unrealistic expectation that their partner should fulfill all of their emotional needs. That said, Consuls can rarely – if ever – be accused of withholding their affections or not investing enough attention in their relationships.

Dating and the Single Consul

Sociable and outgoing, Consuls find it easy to branch out and meet new people. They understand the social conventions related to dating, and they stick to them. On the plus side, this means that Consuls rarely embarrass themselves when approaching a potential partner, and they don't waste undue time and effort pursuing someone who ignores or rejects them. Deep down, Consuls hope to find a partner who cherishes and validates them, and even before the relationship begins, they expect a potential partner to be enthusiastic about the match.

Consuls take all relationship stages seriously. Even if they have just started dating someone, they care about making a good impression and fostering a connection. Consuls enjoy identifying similarities between themselves and their new partners, from shared interests to similar upbringings. When well balanced, this tendency can create common ground and make their partner feel at ease. Taken too far, however, Consuls may make assumptions about their date that prove untrue. For example, they might assume that a well-dressed date is professionally successful and cares about financial security, even though this isn't necessarily the case.

Firm in their convictions, Consuls often have clear ideas about how dating should work. For example, they might hold strong opinions about who should pay, which types of outings are appropriate, what their date should wear, or even how quickly text messages should be returned. If their potential partner fails to conform to these ideals, Consuls might be tempted to move on. As part of their personal development, Consuls must learn to distinguish between expectations and core values. This discernment enables Consuls to accept that people who don't fulfill every last one of their expectations can still be a match on a more fundamental level.

Consuls in the Bedroom

Consuls are very much in touch with the physical world, and when combined with their emotional intelligence, this quality makes them great sexual partners. Affectionate and sensual, Consuls see intimacy as a fantastic way to make their partner happy. As in other areas of the relationship, Consuls do their best to anticipate and fulfill their partners' needs in the bedroom. For many Consuls, their pleasure is only amplified by their partners' pleasure.

That said, Consuls' traditional orientation can make them uncomfortable with sexual experimentation, particularly anything they perceive as taboo. Depending on their background, they may have narrow personal definitions of acceptable sexual behavior. If a Consul's partner suggests something outside of their comfort zone, Consuls may feel pressured or turned off.

Consuls are generally bold in communicating their preferences, but this trait may not extend to their sex lives, particularly if they were raised in a relatively straitlaced household. As a result, Consuls may not be comfortable expressing what feels good to them sexually, let alone what isn't working. In these cases, Consuls might feel hurt or even resentful that their partners can't read their minds.

Alas, it's never fair to expect another person to intuit our needs or desires. As many Consuls discover, this type of expectation only leads to disappointment and frustration. Learning to communicate honestly and unreservedly about their own sexual preferences is essential for this type, and a wise priority to address early in a sexual relationship.

Breakups: Taking the High Road

Consuls like steady and predictable advancement in life, and a breakup is an assault on those goals. When someone breaks up with them, Consuls feel deeply hurt or criticized. They may take the end of the relationship very personally, dwelling on the ways their former partner has let them down.

That said, Consuls are generally willing to initiate a breakup when their partner doesn't share their vision for advancement. Many Consuls have a specific idea of what a "successful" life looks like – from what kind of

house they'd like to live in to where they'd send their children to school. If their partner disagrees, that may well be a deal-breaker.

Alas, Consuls sometimes pull the trigger on a breakup too soon. For Consuls, relationship molehills can quickly grow into mountains, particularly if they rehash old arguments. Consuls generally feel as if they are in the right, and it may be difficult for them to recognize the ways in which they've contributed to relationship conflicts – which, in turn, prevents them from recognizing the ways in which they could resuscitate the relationship.

After a breakup, Consuls are wise to seek the company of friends and family. This type is energized by social contact, and the company of their loved ones can remind them that a bad experience with one person doesn't diminish their ability to connect with someone else. Hugs, attention, and gestures of emotional support go a long way with Consuls, helping them to bounce back from the pain of a breakup.

That said, these interactions shouldn't devolve into ex-bashing. Consuls may need to resist the temptation to dwell on things their former partner did wrong or ways their partner hurt them. Although venting can be healthy, Consuls won't be able to progress and grow if they indulge in harangues or tell everyone about their exes' shortcomings. By moving on respectfully, Consuls can take the high road after even a contentious breakup, accepting what didn't work while honoring the lessons that they've learned.

Potential Personality Pairings

The Right Approach

Balanced Consuls don't impose their opinions or their ways of doing things on their partner. Instead, they value the quirks and tendencies that make their partner unique. Although they strongly prefer a partner who shares their core values, balanced Consuls are self-assured enough to share their lives with someone who may not agree with them on every count. In other words, they expect respect and acceptance from their partners, not constant validation.

While romance is far from an exact science, balanced Consuls understand that putting their best foot forward achieves the best

results. With so many personality variables in play, this often means proceeding into the unknown with an open mind, knowing that while they cannot control other people's behavior, maintaining a positive, accepting attitude brings out the best in others.

The information presented in the following sections will help Consuls build and navigate successful relationships. Knowledge of personality tendencies enables Consuls do what they do best: connect with others. This personality type is devoted and caring, but since true love is unlikely to be found in a perfect package, they must cultivate flexibility and openness in order to maintain a healthy relationship.

With that in mind, we offer a helpful look at some of the ways Consuls and other types are likely to interact, as well as insights to help Consuls maximize their chances for happiness by creating fulfilling, balanced relationships with those types.

Consul-Analyst Relationships

Balanced Consul-Analyst Relationships

A Romantic Mental Checklist

Consuls and Analysts both approach finding a partner with a mental checklist of what they want. Although Consuls may not do this consciously, they are drawn to people who feel familiar – ideally people who share similar traditions and experiences. The characteristics that Consuls desire in a partner have a great deal to do with societal expectations and potentially also traditional gender roles.

Fortunately, Analysts can satisfy a number of items on most Consuls' lists. Many Analysts are ambitious and decisive – two traits that Consuls deeply appreciate. Personal integrity is also important to many

Analysts, and their forthright, honest natures appeal to Consuls, who want a partner they can trust and respect.

Of course, a checklist can't guarantee a successful relationship. At times, Consuls may need to relax their expectations for potential partners, prioritizing only those that truly matter. That said, by honestly communicating what they want, both Consuls and Analysts can establish a foundation that increases their potential to find a compatible partner and build mutually satisfying love.

Love and Efficiency

Consuls may initially be attracted to Analysts' penchant for solving life's puzzles – as long as it's not overdone. This trait helps to advance the relationship, as Consuls feel especially appreciated and loved whenever their Analyst partners do something to help them or make their lives easier. Provided that Analysts take the time to express their ideas in concrete terms, they can also satisfy Consuls' desires for clarity, certainty, and efficiency. In return, the fact that Consuls don't get lost in ideas stabilizes ever-imaginative Analysts, something especially needed by those with the Prospecting trait.

As time progresses, a focus on efficiency and accomplishment can help Consuls and Analysts weather the storms of everyday life together. Consuls crave order and security, and so their actions tend to be grounded and practical, aimed at clear, steady advancement. When they fall into ruts, balanced Consuls appreciate their Analyst partners' innovative, unconventional approach to solving problems and wringing the greatest benefit out of life. As long as each partner taps into the other's strengths, Consuls and Analysts make a formidable pair.

The Long Haul

For distinct reasons, both Consuls and Analysts seek longevity in a relationship. Consuls want to make a "home" – in a real or a metaphorical sense – where they can ground their sense of identity and potentially start a family. Beyond this domestic drive, they also want reliable partners who assist them in reaching their goals, and balanced Analysts, ever logical, fulfill this need.

In turn, sensible, energetic Consuls can serve as a stabilizing force in Analysts' lives, ensuring that practical matters aren't neglected. Consuls can support Analysts in less obvious ways as well. Although they are rational to the bone, Analysts actually cherish a loving partner like a Consul. Many Analysts struggle to interpret others' emotions, and it may be a relief to find someone who so obviously cares about them.

The result? Even though they are driven by different motivations, Consuls' and Analysts' sense of loyalty are a solid match.

Unbalanced Consul-Analyst Relationships

Snowballing Disagreements

In the initial phases of a relationship, Consuls and Analysts often find themselves united in their drive for achievement and advancement. Over time, however, the harmony and predictability that Consuls crave may be disrupted by Analysts' desire to continually improve things. Analysts love to explore new ideas and possibilities, but they usually know when to embrace things as they are. When their experimental impulses become unbalanced, however, Analysts may pursue change after change, trying to improve every aspect of their lives through constant upheaval.

Consuls strive to build stable, predictable home lives, and they may be frustrated or confused when their partners seem to want something different. Even worse, Consuls may feel personally judged and criticized when Analysts cast about for new solutions and ways to improve things. Unless addressed, this sense of hurt can corrode the relationship from the inside.

In this situation, Consuls may find themselves digging in their heels and single-mindedly defending on the status quo. Their Analyst partners might, in turn, accuse them of being unimaginative. As a result, small conflicts can snowball into hurtful arguments that highlight fundamental differences in the relationship. This dynamic can ensue during any type of disagreement – whether over an ethical issue or where to eat dinner.

As an example, Consuls might insist on a traditional, formal style of home décor, whereas Analysts might favor something simpler. In this case, a relatively small issue – how to decorate the house – can escalate

into a heated exchange, with Analysts accusing their Consul partners of a shallow or small-minded preoccupation with appearances and Consuls feeling personally and unfairly attacked. Unless they cultivate mutual respect, couples in this situation may find themselves trapped in increasingly frequent patterns of conflict and disagreement.

Details vs. the Big Picture

Thanks to their Observant trait, Consuls are attentive to concrete details and practical matters, and they crave stability and predictability. They have a firm sense of how every aspect of their life should be ordered, from their schedules to their medicine cabinets, and they know what – and whom – they like or dislike. This type of existence brings Consuls comfort and meaning, helping them make sense of an otherwise messy, changeable world.

Alas, Analysts are hardly known for their attention to details or practicalities. In Consul-Analyst relationships, Consuls may be dismayed by Analysts' inability or unwillingness to meet their standards of how things should be done. When a tidy home matters to Consuls, they will be frustrated every time their Analyst partners drop the mail on the floor or leave the cap off the toothpaste.

These tiny infractions can accrue significance over time, leading Consuls to feel that their partners don't respect them, meet their expectations, or fit into their lives. When Consuls do communicate their preferences and wishes, their Analyst partners might dismiss these opinions as illogical, trivial, or pointless. "What difference does it make," Analysts might ask, "if the dishes hang out in the sink for a while? Shouldn't we be focused on more important issues, like particle physics or international relations?" For Consuls, however, the dishes may indeed be important.

When their partners don't understand or honor their preferences, Consuls often find themselves harboring resentment or judgment. On a practical level, Consuls may feel they do all the work, laboring to keep the day-to-day details in order while their Analyst partner goes on about things that feel annoyingly irrelevant and unhelpful. Occasional spats over toothpaste caps may not matter much, but over time, these tensions can come to eclipse the love, affection, and trust that Consuls need to feel in order for their relationships to flourish.

Rebalancing Consul-Analyst Relationships

Respecting the Needs of the Moment and the Future

In unbalanced relationships, Consuls tire of their Analyst partners' grand, impractical ideas for the future, not to mention the constant exploring and experimenting that Analysts love to indulge in. These efforts, from Consuls' point of view, consume time, energy, and resources that could and *should* be directed toward more practical matters. Understandably, Consuls in this situation might feel tempted to roll their eyes at their partners or badger them to take care of present-moment demands.

For Consuls, a more constructive approach is to get curious about Analysts' grand ideas. The best way to do this: ask thought-provoking questions that help *both* partners better understand what's at stake and what the payoffs might be. For example, Consuls could ask their Analyst partners how long a given project would take, what resources it would require, what opportunity costs it would entail, and what benefits it would offer. This type of discussion makes both partners feel heard, and by asking thoughtful questions, Consuls can help ground even Analysts' most high-flying ideas.

Remembering Why They Fell in Love

The honeymoon phase of a romantic relationship may be sweet, but it isn't sustainable. Over time, even devoted couples can become increasingly annoyed by each other's habits and behaviors – whether minor quirks or major traits. Unbalanced couples can easily become overwhelmed by their differences, to the extent that they lose sight of what drew them together in the first place.

In this situation, it's helpful for Consuls to remember *why* they fell in love. Before giving up on their relationships, Consuls might want to sit down and write a list of all the qualities that once appealed to them about their partners. These should be qualities that the partners still embody – for example, their intelligence, their honesty, or their wit. Consuls who truly struggle to remember their partners' good qualities might try looking through old photos, recalling the details of their first dates, or even chatting with a few friends to see what they remember. (Ideally, these conversations should focus on a partner's positive traits, not their shortcomings.) After drawing up this list, Consuls might be moved by

how many strengths and gifts their partner brings to the relationship. If they'd like, Consuls can share this list with their partners, but it is fine for them to keep this list as a private reminder of why they fell in love.

Choosing Battles and Letting Go

Consuls and Analysts both bring strong opinions and full-fledged worldviews to the table, which can be a beautiful thing. When their perspectives don't align, however, Consul-Analyst pairs may find themselves deadlocked. In unbalanced couples, both parties feel confident about the "rightness" of their approach, unwilling to cede any ground to each other or pursue true compromise.

As in other areas, Consuls can take the high ground in these standoffs, actively assessing how important a given point of contention truly is to them. To respond appropriately in these situations, Consuls can ask themselves the following questions: *On a scale of one to 10, how important is this issue to me? What is the worst that would happen if my partner got their way? In one year, will this matter to me?* By asking themselves these questions, Consuls can determine whether their resistance to their partners' point of view is motivated by their core values or by the desire to be right. When they realize a particular argument isn't all that important to them, Consuls can decide to focus their energies on other aspects of their lives and their relationships.

Consul-Diplomat Relationships

Balanced Consul-Diplomat Relationships

A Little Heaven and a Little Earth

When they first date, Consuls and Diplomats may feel like kindred spirits. Consuls are often moved by Diplomats' altruistic natures, which

resonate with Consuls' own desire to care for others on a practical level. As the relationship matures, Consuls can serve as a kind of kite string, helping Diplomats ground and realize their high-flying, almost spiritual desire to help others. Meanwhile, Consuls can enjoy the view from the heavens that Diplomats offer.

Consuls help support their quixotic partners by leading the way in day-to-day activities, better integrating Diplomats in both the household and the community. In this relationship, both partners share a drive to create harmony and help others, and Consuls can turn Diplomats' idealism into something that can be acted upon, whether it's an entrepreneurial project or a great idea for a vacation together. Across all of their relationships, Consuls express their love and care by helping others to focus their lives. The intimacy of romance motivates Consuls to place all the more importance on providing that help to the person they love most.

A Caring Couple

Both Consuls and Diplomats have an interest in nurturing others. Consuls aim to create the type of stable environment where they believe their loved ones can flourish, and their Diplomat partners feel moved to support the mental and spiritual growth of others. The result can be an aligned, caring partnership that is fulfilling on many levels.

Even in the earliest stages of a relationship, these two can bring out the best in each other. Consuls may find that time spent with Diplomats motivates them to live out their ideals, whether that means throwing a surprise birthday party for a loved one or spearheading a major philanthropic initiative. As the relationship progresses, Consuls can cultivate a cooperative dynamic with their Diplomat partners, working together to create a sense of purpose, meaning, and even – to Consuls' delight – accomplishment.

More Than the Sum of Their Parts

When Consuls meet Diplomats, they might marvel at how easily the conversation flows. Consuls are engaging, talkative partners who enjoy sharing their experiences, likes, dislikes, and beliefs. But balanced Consuls also actively listen, allowing their Diplomat partners to express

their deeper values, including their grand ideas about the intangible meaning of experiences and beliefs. This helps their Diplomat partners feel appreciated and understood – something they crave, and something Consuls love to provide. These relationships can deepen quickly through heartfelt respect and admiration.

As time progresses, balanced Consul-Diplomat relationships grow on a foundation of compatible values, not simple similarities, or even shared opinions. While Consuls and Diplomats arrive at their values differently, these are both values-driven types. Consuls derive their values from their communities or traditions, and Diplomats look to high concepts and philosophy to guide them. As long as each person respects and appreciates the other's worldview, then this principled approach to life can help Consuls and Diplomats see that, as a couple, they are more than the sum of their parts. Together, they may feel called to nurture others in a way that radiates selflessness. In other words, they may feel that their partnership can benefit and be meaningful for not only themselves, but also the other people in their lives.

Unbalanced Consul-Diplomat Relationships

Practicality versus Utopia

It's a beautiful thing when Consuls and Diplomats balance each other, but these partnerships don't always unfold in balance. At first, Consuls may be intrigued by Diplomats' utopian inclinations. Once the novelty wears off, however, Consuls may chafe at the impracticality of Diplomats' ideas and ideals.

Particularly if they get to the point of moving in together, Consuls may expect their Diplomat partners to settle down and become more practical. For present-minded Consuls, Diplomats' focus on the future can seem flighty, annoying, or even irresponsible. To Consuls' dismay, Diplomats might lose themselves in concerns about global warming or the expanding universe and forget to buy milk on the way home.

Observant and Intuitive individuals always differ in this way, and the discrepancy can show itself even in couples' everyday conversations. Diplomats often want to talk about an endless stream of *what ifs*, causing

Consuls to lose their patience – particularly if they'd rather be talking about an urgent or actionable matter. In an unbalanced relationship, Consuls find themselves shouldering more than their share of practical responsibilities and chores, and their frustration at this state of affairs inevitably surfaces in their day-to-day interactions with their partners.

When Emotions Rule

Both Consuls and Diplomats tend to act based on emotions rather than logic. Yes, they are both capable of thinking coolly and rationally, but their feelings surge in first. In the early stages of a relationship, this similarity can create understanding between Consuls and Diplomats, but in unbalanced relationships, it can come to trigger significant tension.

Alas, sometimes couples need to be deal with hard facts. For Consul-Diplomat couples, emotions can all too often take precedence over reality. For example, if they fall in love with a house that's beyond their budget, they may need to abandon their sentimental notions and move on. Otherwise, the relationship may become derailed by financial strain.

When both partners make decisions based on feelings, there is the potential for a constant state of drama. Sure, drama can be positive – such as enthusiasm and romance – but it can also be toxic, triggering resentment and deep hurt. It's true that Consuls' Judging trait compels order, but under the burden of excessive emotionality it will falter. In these circumstances, small arguments can balloon into major blowouts.

To complicate things further, Consuls rarely hold back their opinions, and Diplomats rarely contain their feelings. As a result, these two may find themselves butting heads in a big way, unleashing an almost overwhelming exchange of emotion. In these situations, Consuls might seethe with disdain, leading their Diplomat partners to feel judged and dismissed.

Rebalancing Consul-Diplomat Relationships

Cultivating an Open Mind

Consuls know what they like – and what they dislike. This decisiveness is useful in many circumstances, but lasting love requires openness

and compromise. In unbalanced partnerships, Consuls expect their Diplomat partners to agree with them and accede to their preferences, from what kind of car they should buy to which way the toilet paper should be loaded. To be fair, these details might matter more to Consuls than to Diplomats, but if Consuls expect their partners to validate and uphold all of their preferences, then the relationship will never feel truly equal or fulfilling.

In balanced relationships, Consuls listen to and acknowledge their partners' opinions and preferences. Before jumping in with their own ideas and expectations – even if it's just about where to eat dinner – Consuls can practice asking their partners the following questions: *What would you like to do? What about that course of action appeals to you? How strongly do you feel about this issue?* By listening before they share their own opinions, Consuls can foster balanced relationships that are founded on mutuality and compromise, not getting their own way.

Caution with Criticism

Criticism can seriously undermine Consul-Diplomat relationships. Due to their Feeling trait, each partner can suffer emotional wounds from even well-intended feedback, let alone harsh rebukes. It's normal for all partners to experience hurt feelings from time to time, even in loving relationships, and couples can recover from occasional lapses in kindness or judgment. That said, if criticism or contempt is expressed with regularity – especially between people as sensitive as Consuls and Diplomats – recovery may be difficult.

If criticism or feedback is necessary, it's important that it be conveyed with care and respect. In all cases, but especially for a Consul-Diplomat couple, the conversation should center on *specific* actions, instances, and feelings, not sweeping judgments or put-downs. In other words, *I felt angry when you*... is more constructive than *Why do you have to be so lazy?* By being specific rather than general, it is possible to highlight a bothersome behavior without condemning the person responsible for that behavior. This reduces the likelihood of defensiveness or resentment.

The formula for this type of communication is simple: *I feel [emotion] when you [act that triggers the feeling]*. For example, "I feel lonely when

you stay at work past eight p.m.," or "I feel frustrated when you don't take the trash out after you've promised."

Ideally, these discussions should be balanced by expressions of praise and appreciation. The same formula can apply for these cases. For example, "I feel so happy when we take walks together," or, "I feel confident and reassured when you say you believe in me."

Deal with the Facts

Consuls and Diplomats are perfectly capable of critical thinking, but they may need to make special efforts to spot their "default" emotional inclinations. Otherwise, they are at risk of triggering conflict and stress due to overromanticizing, overdramatizing, or other excessive emotional responses. To minimize needless drama, these couples must learn to recognize when emotions are best brushed aside – at least temporarily.

That said, Consul-Diplomat couples will never dispense with emotional considerations altogether, nor should they. In the right circumstances, their feelings can lead them to make constructive, meaningful choices. For example, their emotional natures might inspire them to move to a city they love, spend more time in nature, or adopt a pet.

So how can Consuls honor their feelings without indulging in drama? First, they should identify the thoughts or beliefs that underlie a given emotional response. For example, if they're incensed that their partner forgot to take out the trash yet again, Consuls might recognize an underlying belief that their partner doesn't respect them or even that their partner will never get their act together. The second step is for Consuls to ask themselves: *Is this really true?* Finally, Consuls can ask themselves: *How would I feel if I let go of this thought or belief? Would I feel relieved, or would I feel as if I'm negating my true values and needs?* These questions can help Consuls balance their emotional insights with self-awareness and insight.

Consul-Sentinel Relationships

Balanced Consul-Sentinel Relationships

Comfort and Commitment

Couples sharing many core traits have an easier time understanding each other, so a Consul-Sentinel pairing is often a comfortable match. Relationships between Consuls and other Sentinels thrive on a sense of duty, caring, and practical order. While the specifics may differ, each understands the other's desire to build useful foundations and maintain the traditions that define their worlds. Both partners appreciate a clear path forward, and try to proceed sensibly and smoothly without complicating things. When two Sentinels enter a relationship, a deeply responsible mutual caretaking can develop that is unequalled among other personality types.

From the moment they decide to commit, things are quite serious between Consuls and Sentinels. Both feel a strong pull to stabilize things. They want to focus on building a better, more certain life, and having someone with the same values adds to their momentum. They enjoy feeling that they have found "the one," and when they find someone who aligns with their vision of what they want in a partner, they don't waffle or fret. They commit.

Easy Compatibility

Consuls love Sentinels for their sensible natures and the steady effort they put into life. From the start, these two embrace established wisdom and understanding rather than abstract, theoretical musings. That's not to say their relationships are devoid of imagination, but they find that putting their energy into realistic matters and proven methods tends to be more productive. Their attention to immediate needs assures them

that their lives will improve consistently. When they dream of a better future, they do so by embracing reasonable, achievable goals.

This couple works well together from an early stage, with Consuls contributing an attentive, devoted sensibility and their Sentinel partners providing their own unique forms of prudence and perseverance. Unlike those who feel rewarded by dreaming in and of itself, this couple feels a sense of purposeful satisfaction when they accomplish practical goals. As time progresses, they may discover differences in their ways of engaging the world, but their respective approaches lead them in compatible directions.

Protecting Those They Love

The name "Sentinel" is no accident. People with this Role do everything in their power to protect the people close to them. To do so, they aim to create an ideal life – more specifically, what they'd consider an ideal life – for their loved ones. Relationships can bring out the best in these types, from their constancy to their drive to serve.

When Consuls partner with other Sentinels, the two can work together to transform their relationship into the protective haven that they so crave. In so doing, Consuls gain a dual benefit: they foster the security they need *and* they extend that order and stability to the people they love. Over time, this type of relationship can open Consuls' hearts even further, enabling them to feel that they are fulfilling their true purpose in life.

Unbalanced Consul-Sentinel Relationships

Too Much of a Good Thing

When two individuals with similar traits fall in love, the combination can result in too much of a good thing. Even tradition-bound Sentinels pass through stages of change, becoming bored or frustrated with the very routines that once made them happy. There is a difference between satisfaction and joy, and these types may become so focused on stability and duty that the pleasure drains from their lives, leaving only predictable routine in its place.

The danger is even worse if one partner feels stifled while the other craves constancy. If their partners desire change, Consuls may interpret this as an abandonment of everything they have built together. Conversely, Consuls who feel stifled may resent or blame their partners for their state. Whether their partners push for change or try to maintain an unhappy routine, Consuls may lash out, heaping judgment and resentment on the person who once seemed like their soulmate.

Missed Opportunities

Unbalanced Consul-Sentinel couples don't venture beyond their comfort zone, and so they may ignore highly beneficial opportunities that seem too risky. Even if they never disagree on aspects of their life together, such a couple may become insulated inside the worlds they know. When they reinforce one another's reliance on the status quo, these partners never discover their options, much less explore them. Consuls' ambition and willpower don't guarantee that they will seize new opportunities, especially if their Sentinel partners also stick to a well-trodden path.

Personal growth, success, and prosperity almost always entail a measure of risk. However, unbalanced Consul-Sentinel partners support each other's security rather than their growth. Trying a new path may seem pointless when a perfectly good situation already exists – especially one they worked so hard to create together. If these types reassure each other that change is not needed, they hold each other back. Worse, they may deliberately ignore circumstances that desperately need improvement.

Certainty upon Certainty

When they date other Sentinels, Consuls may appreciate their partners' decisive, clear-cut approach to life. But if the Judging trait overheats as the relationship progresses, the result is a recipe for tension and conflict. Unless Consul-Sentinel couples learn to cope with disagreements, their stubborn determination can consume the harmony from their relationship like a flame consumes oxygen.

Once Consuls decide something is correct, they stick to that decision. If their partner disagrees, Consuls might feel affronted, judgmental,

or even self-righteous. This behavior can manifest in their Sentinel partners as well. The Judging trait inevitably conveys a degree of decisiveness, an intrinsic certainty of thought. However, this in no way assures common preferences between the couple: one may like chocolate, the other, vanilla. The only thing they may agree on is that each wants their own way.

Even when Consuls *do* routinely get their way, this doesn't mean that the relationship is on good footing. People with this personality type may feel pleased or appeased when their wishes are honored, but high-handedness – even with the best of intentions – can be damaging to the other partner's sense of worth. Controlling behavior is truly the dark side of willfulness, and it undermines the practical compromise that all balanced Sentinels embrace. When one partner makes all of the decisions, long-term happiness cannot prosper because freedom is not shared.

Rebalancing Consul-Sentinel Relationships

Venture into Something New Together

When Consuls and Sentinels meet, they may enjoy the sense of security that comes from being with someone who also values tradition and the status quo. If the relationship veers into unbalanced terrain, however, they may find themselves clinging to old patterns and routines, even those that no longer work. As a result, Consuls may feel stuck, stifled, or limited, although the reasons for these feelings may not be apparent.

Balanced individuals navigate successfully through life by adapting and growing. In this spirit, Consul-Sentinel couples can shake things up occasionally to find new opportunities and joys. Improvement is by definition a type of change, and must be sought consciously. A foray outside their routine is the first step for this couple to achieve greater pleasure, strength, and happiness within the relationship. Fortunately, once such determined types engage in something together, they generate their own momentum, as they do not commit lightly or give up easily.

The key for this couple is to agree *together* to make an ongoing effort to expand. To cure or prevent stagnation, they can schedule monthly

or quarterly conversations where they discuss new things they can learn, do, or try together. They might identify one thing to try in each of the following areas: domestic routines, romantic activities, hobbies, and social/community life. By approaching these changes together, the couple can grow in tandem, taking advantage of each other's reliable support.

Compromise Is Necessary

The Judging trait, with all of its certitude, doesn't have to lock people into inflexibility or rigidity. But if it does, the heart holds the key. When this couple disagrees, they must remind themselves of the deep appreciation they feel for each other's presence in their lives. The love they share is what motivates compromise. Fairly supporting each other's preferences doesn't require either partner to change their own – just that they honor the other's wishes, going along with them at least some of the time.

Balanced Consuls make a special effort to support their partners' needs and desires. No matter how certain a Consul is that pumpkin pie *must* be served at the holidays, their partner's tastes deserve respectful consideration and inclusion. Otherwise, Consuls' partners will feel dismissed, disrespected, or unfairly judged.

Whenever they find themselves at odds with their partners, Consuls can ask themselves "On a scale of one to 10, how much does this issue matter to me?" If the answer is six or less, Consuls can experiment with acceding to their partners' wishes and noticing how this feels. By doing so, Consuls may find that cultivating compromise feels even better than getting their way.

Consul-Explorer Relationships

Balanced Consul-Explorer Relationships

Opposites Attract

Consul-Explorer couples may seem like an odd combination, but they can be quite compatible. Early in the relationship, Consuls often appreciate that, as Observant types, Explorers are hands-on and present-minded. They may also enjoy Explorers' relative flexibility, which enables Explorers to embrace every moment as an opportunity for immediate satisfaction or accomplishment.

The truth is that two vastly different people can enjoy a wonderfully balanced and joyful relationship. Consuls may find themselves attracted to Explorers during times when they recognize a need for more excitement, relaxation, and spontaneity in their lives. Explorers certainly bring enjoyment to the table, thanks to their ability to find the fun even in ordinary situations, attack challenges that seem somehow interesting or inspiring, and kick back when necessary. As the relationship progresses, Consuls can offer practical support that keeps Explorers' lives functioning, allowing both partners to enjoy the advantages of a stable, secure home base.

Discovery and Security

Explorers broaden Consuls' worlds. By gently tugging Consuls out of their comfort zone and their sense of how things "should" be done, Explorers can add variety, excitement, and novelty to Consuls' lives. Consuls might not always admit they need this, but balanced Consuls in particular may crave some of the joy and freedom that runs through Explorers' veins.

Beyond practical assistance, Consuls can support Explorers on a deep emotional level. Many Explorers have experienced challenging times during their younger years, particularly if their unique personalities didn't fit in and their strengths weren't appreciated. This type of childhood can affect their sense of belonging for the rest of their lives. When Consuls love Explorers, their care can fulfill Explorers' basic need for nurturance and positive attention. In such cases, the result is often a real and satisfying emotional union for both partners.

Unbalanced Consul-Explorer Relationships

Roles That Grow Old

Opposites may attract, but over time, Consuls and Explorers can fall into unbalanced roles that become so distinct and repetitive that they create separation instead of unity. If Consuls take on the responsibilities of organizing, planning, and meeting obligations, they may become frustrated with Explorers' "just want to have fun" attitude. Although these roles can work well when each partner feels the benefits of the other's approach, they quickly grow tiresome and oppressive if taken too far.

In an unbalanced relationship, this dynamic might start to resemble that of a parent and child. It's burdensome for Consuls to take all the responsibility while Explorers enjoy a carefree existence, and if Consuls impose rules and expectations, Explorers may feel stifled or patronized. Consuls won't hold back their judgment or frustration regarding this imbalance for long, and they may even unleash criticism or contempt that opens old wounds for Explorers.

Collision Course

Consuls have firm, long-held opinions and convictions, whereas Explorers adapt and change course fairly easily. This relationship arrangement may work at first, but as it progresses, Consuls might chafe whenever Explorers defy their battery of "shoulds": how things *should* be done, how a relationship *should* progress, and – in the case of parents – how children *should* be raised.

This conflict can come to a head regarding the issue of commitment. In a relationship, Consuls may insist on defining the level of commitment

early on, particularly if they feel eager to settle down or start a family. On the flip side, Explorers' independence often makes them resist a committed lifestyle, at least right away. Explorers can demonstrate great longevity in love, but if they feel pressured by too many strict demands, they may try to escape or pull away – something that is especially hurtful to Consuls, who crave total loyalty from their partners. If one partner seeks commitment while the other yearns for freedom, the relationship can be fraught with emotional landmines.

Rebalancing Consul-Explorer Relationships

Sharing Responsibilities

In unbalanced relationships, Consuls may try to validate themselves by playing "parent" in their households, taking care of practical chores and obligations – or nagging their partners to do so. They may also keep score in their minds, noting all the ways they do more than their partner to keep things running smoothly. The result, unfortunately, is resentment and contempt – not exactly the ingredients for a happy relationship.

The solution to this situation is respect: both self-respect and respect for the other partner. Without building up grudges, balanced Consuls recognize when the scales of responsibility are tilted too far in their direction. In this situation, they speak their needs and respectfully ask their partners to help out. A balanced Consul might say, "I'm super stressed and busy, so would you do a load of laundry to help me out?" In this situation, it's important for Consuls to release some of their expectations. The laundry might not be done *exactly* how they would do it, but that's all right.

Balanced Consuls also remember that they fell in love with someone who has a higher tolerance for disorder and a lower tolerance for mundane activity. When they want their Explorer partners to help out, Consuls can spice up chores by playing music or turning the activity into a game – for example, "Let's see how many things we can put away while this song plays." In a loving relationship, nobody should confuse encouraging more responsibility with demanding it, but both partners must participate.

Benefitting from Each Other's Ways

Consuls in unbalanced relationships may begin to see the world in black and white. They may put themselves and their partners in boxes – for example, "All you care about is having fun," or "All I do is work, so I don't have any time to relax." This isn't the full truth, however. Consuls are perfectly capable of releasing control and relaxing, and Explorers can certainly make practical contributions to the relationship.

So how can Consuls break through the walls that keep them – and their partners – trapped in unproductive patterns? The answer, surprisingly, is to ask their partner for input. Even in the worst relationship stalemates, "What would you do in my place?" is a powerful question.

For example, Consuls who find themselves locked into doing all the chores might ask their Explorer partners how they would behave if the roles were reversed. This type of communication encourages Explorers to see the situation from Consuls' point of view, motivating them to help remedy the situation. Even if Consuls think they know what their partner will say, they should listen carefully. Open-minded Explorers sometimes have powerful insights that can help Consuls break free of their old roles.

Conclusion

Embracing Possibilities

Relationships present Consuls with wonderful opportunities to grow. Normally, people with this personality type feel little pull to reconsider their opinions, but love can give them powerful a motivation to explore the terrain beyond the world of "should." This won't happen overnight, but balanced Consuls are fully capable of pushing beyond a rut, appreciating the inspiration and guidance they can gain from someone they love and trust. A dedicated partner with a different perspective can brighten Consuls' words and broaden their minds.

In a balanced relationship, Consuls offer incredible devotion and strong emotional support, enabling both their partner and themselves to reach higher and do more than they could alone. When the relationship is founded on acceptance, honesty, and respect, there is no reason why Consuls cannot enjoy a lasting and balanced love with any personality type.

Friendships

Social Foundations

Consuls are very social personality types, seeking large circles of friends and more than willing to spend the time and energy necessary to maintain these relationships. Upbeat and warm, Consuls are known for being welcoming and providing a constant source of emotional support and encouragement. They see friendship as a sacred responsibility as well as a fulfilling pleasure, caring for each friend individually. For this type, being involved in other people's lives is very satisfying, and they love to make a positive difference whenever they can.

Consuls crave a world where people are responsible, trustworthy, and engaged together – friendships that reflect these values satisfy them deeply. Luckily, meeting good people is easy for this type. Consuls cheerfully do what they can to make sure their friends are happy, and being so outgoing and empathetic, their energy wins them many friends. Consuls are comfortably popular in most social environments, and they are often the center of their social circle. Being connected to many people gives Consuls the sense of strength and stability they need to be happy in life.

Sturdy and Stable

Initial connections may be quick and easy for Consuls, but they aren't superficial people. They maintain strong values and views based on their personal traditions, and find especially deep bonds with those who match them in such areas. When it comes to true friends, this type values consistency. They freely give of their hearts and hands alike, but

expect steady commitment from others in return. Vigorous, practical, and emotionally attuned, Consuls make excellent friends, and are always happy to bring another reliable person into their lives.

Where Consuls' desire for solidity limits their social relationships is their unwillingness to accept very different points of view. They tend to be kindhearted, but also aren't easily impressed or enthused by unusual people, preferring an inclusive but tightly defined social order. This is a type who tries to gently guide others toward their own proven values instead of embracing change. They can be a powerful force for good in their community and beyond, always seeking to share the reliable foundation they have created with others.

Commonality and Mutual Reliance

Consuls' way of developing a positive social status is reflected by their friends, as they like being around those with similar culture. Friendships are likely to flourish in environments that reflect what they have decided on through their own experiences. Of course, what's compatible depends on the personal history of each Consul – the only sure thing is that they enjoy a sense of security through practicing consistent beliefs with like-minded individuals.

This type is socially outgoing in whatever community feels like home, but rarely feels pulled to explore contrasting ways of life. However, balanced Consuls seeking to diversify their friendships wisely look for groups formed around any subject they have in common, from gardening to gaming to sports. This is an easy way for this type to bond with people who have different views and backgrounds. Sharing an interest means they will agree on at least that one thing.

Among friends who have earned their loyalty, Consuls are tireless protectors, always trying to create a framework of support and a cooperative sense of mutual reliance. They are great at using their sensitivity to stay in tune with what motivates and drives their friends, and contribute much of themselves to those ends. Where this type often falls short is when one of those friends departs from agreed-upon harmony to try something new, or when a person with challengingly unfamiliar views moves into their social circle. Consuls' empathy and desire to connect sometimes are sometime at war with their need for familiarity.

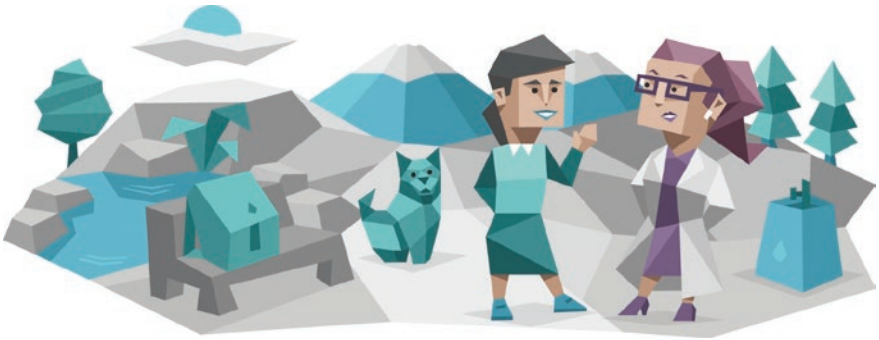
Pleasant Surprises

Consuls' appreciation of conventional social rules doesn't prevent them from building friendships with very different types of people, but they may need time to get to know their virtues as well as their needs. Consuls are quick to offer advice and help to anyone, and this often forms a bridge to bring them closer to those they don't initially understand very well.

It may take a while for Consuls to warm to people with unusual characteristics, but the chance to discover their inner qualities is an exciting challenge for these highly social types. They want to be able to include everyone as a friend – it's just a matter of finding or creating some common ground. Once that happens, Consuls can enjoy friendship with almost anyone.

Consuls and Friends of Other Types

With that in mind, let's look at some of the virtues that this type can share with each Role group through friendship, as well as some areas of potential difficulty. Most importantly, we'll also go over some helpful things Consuls can do to make friendships work with other types.



Consul-Analyst Friendships

Balanced Friendships with Analysts

Energetic Balance

Consul-Analyst friendships don't always form easily, but through friendship these types can nicely balance each other. For example, the headstrong, often confrontational nature of Commanders and Debaters can challenge Consuls' – and everyone else's – patience. Consuls can match the energetic willpower of these types to offer them

some firm advice on creating social harmony when they get too carried away with logic and ego. These Analysts in turn appreciate Consuls' consistent strength, admiring how they refuse to give up and never let down a friend in need.

Not all Analyst friends are so challenging to be around, though. Consuls appreciate the quieter, thoughtful natures of Logicians and Architects. They see how these types take the time to figure out clever solutions, and find their input helpful on nearly everything. It may not always be easy to understand their curious intellectual musings, but Analysts offer Consuls a rational, calculated way of thinking that they often lack. In return, Consuls help Analysts of all types consider angles they normally dismiss, such as human needs and their own emotions, helping them understand themselves better.

Critical Support

More than just personal balance, these friends can offer each other truly valuable, very different kinds of support when problems arise. Each brings very different qualities to the friendship, but when they share their virtues with each other, a bond is formed from which provides strength through good times and bad.

When Consuls face problems, they will find that having Analysts friends knocks mountains down to molehills. Analysts are inspired innovators, and when Consuls need help thinking through a problem critically, they will find logical solutions in abundance. Analyst friends may not be the most obvious choice for tender comfort in times of emotional upset, but when Consuls are drowning in stress over a less personal problem, Analysts offer great support. Consuls like to keep things in order, and sometimes need a logical friend to help them stay on track.

The other side of that coin is that Analysts often don't know how to ask for help when they are troubled by sadness, loss, or worry, instead trying to think their way out of their very natural feelings. Consuls see right past this veneer of intellectuality to give the kind of comfort and understanding that Analysts don't even know they need. Analysts might not find Consuls to be the most enthusiastic partners in intellectual pursuits, but they come to deeply appreciate having a friend who openly cares for them regardless of their mental ability.

Unbalanced Friendships with Analysts

Disappointing Disconnection

There are challenges, of course – in an unbalanced friendship, Consuls find Analysts to be emotionally distant and annoyingly focused on creative ideas rather than grounded reality. The fact that Consuls prioritize social connections and Analysts like to theorize about impersonal ideas is a stumbling block. These two might live in clashing mental time zones, as well, as Consuls focus on what is, while Analysts focus on what might be. Consuls may roll their eyes dismissively at Analysts' grand, esoteric technical plans, and they may in turn be frustrated by Analysts' rejection of the social fabric that they themselves find so vital.

To make this disconnection worse, Analysts may take a neglectful attitude toward maintaining friendships. Once they put in the initial effort to establish a good friendship, they often take it for granted, thinking nothing of long silences or absences. This robs Consuls of the frequent contact that makes them so happy, creating an impression that Analysts simply don't care. This is unacceptable to Consuls, for whom nothing is more important than friends, family, and their chosen social community. Their attempts to encourage Analysts to engage socially may not always be successful, though, and those Analysts who don't make enough time for their Consul friends may find themselves out in the cold.

Perceptions of Weakness

Even in an established friendship, Consuls and Analysts can both suffer from stubbornness and may look dimly on what they feel are each other flaws. When in balance, basic tolerance as well as deep appreciation of each other's virtues more than makes up for these kinds of negative appraisals, but when unbalanced, both these types can be harsh.

Consuls may find Analysts to be inconsiderate because they are often blind to feelings. Analysts can sometimes be seriously lacking in this area, and Consuls may consider this an unforgivable deficiency – an inability to act human. When Consuls are upset with Analysts' social ineptitude, they don't simply walk away, they try to "fix" them. Unfortunately, their solution is usually to exert pressure on Analysts

to conform to their own social ideals. This may be anything from open verbal disapproval to passive aggressive criticism, but is unlikely to be put in rational terms that get through to Analysts, who in turn just feel confused and resentful.

For their part, Analysts may come to view their Consul friends as weak for always being so personally sensitive and concerned about others' feelings. This may seem not only like gullible vulnerability to Analysts but also like a pointless waste of time. Analysts in unbalanced friendships may see preoccupation with emotion and social harmony as ignoring fundamental reality, and they may tend to look down on those who prioritize intangible things like compassion, empathy, and human relationships. They deeply offend their Consul friends when they disparage the kinds of social goals that Consuls prize so highly.

Rebalancing Friendships with Analysts

Enjoying Each Other's Virtues

Consuls and Analysts can maintain a good connection by remembering the benefits of being friends. Consuls contribute critical qualities that Analysts often lack: realism, grounded practicality, and emotional understanding. Analysts often end up getting a bit lost in their own universe, and Consuls keep them in touch with humanity by offering a satisfying connection to good things in life. It's OK to live in a mental laboratory, but sharing a laugh over pizza and iced cream with a good friend is something that even the most cerebral Analysts appreciate. Analysts don't have to sacrifice their own ideas and priorities to connect warmly with Consuls, they just have to accept the outstretched hand.

Analysts aren't the only ones who need to make an effort to stay connected in this friendship. While social overtures come easy to Consuls, they may give little time to the things that drive Analysts. One way to overcome this is games; Analysts are very likely to be fond of some type of game, anything from golf to video games to tennis. Engaging games can be an easy gateway to spending fulfilling time together. It might not offer the deeper emotional connection that Consuls crave, but is at least a way to share companionable joy – not a bad compromise.

These friends might have to be deliberate about their compromises when finding things to do together, and can set themselves the goal of each doing three things per month that the other cares about. Good times together can be created almost anywhere, and if each friend gets to lead the way into something they like, they can likewise accept the responsibility to also make it can be fun for the other person.

Emotional Honesty

Analysts may not even realize they are losing their Consul friends by not being engaged or considerate enough, and emotional subtlety won't likely reach them. To be clear, Consuls can put what they feel into basic terms, and tell it with a cool, relaxed attitude. They must tell Analysts when something is important, be it a feeling, a thought, or social ideas, and it's also helpful to let them know what to do. Analysts value their friends deeply, but can be quite blind to their needs. Rebalancing this requires patient communication in language that makes sense to both friends.

Consideration goes both ways, and balanced Consuls work to respect Analysts' seemingly unfamiliar ways of thinking, including a tendency to be reserved with their deepest feelings. Consuls can gently draw out Analysts' deeper feelings by asking questions, but also recognize when it is time to let things be. Analyst should feel free to say when they have reach their limits, and balanced Consuls understand that trusting honesty doesn't always mean absolute openness. Some people just need to keep parts of themselves to themselves in order to feel secure. Instead of trying to force Analysts' feelings out, Consuls can let them know that they are accepted, whether they choose to be fully open or not.

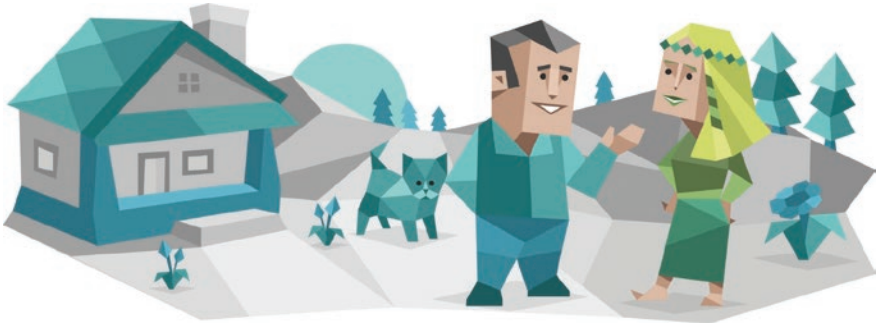
Thoughtful Support

A functioning, balanced friendship with an Analyst is certainly rewarding for both sides. Consuls offer Analysts a sensitive ear for their intellectual ranting that helps soothe their frustration with a dysfunctional world. Being dutiful, stable, and proactive is natural for this type, and Analysts especially need steadfast friends willing to take the time to understand them.

In turn, Consuls gain sincere and thoughtful support from their Analyst friends, whose vigorous minds are always at the ready. Analysts lead

them into knowledge they might not discover through their more conventional perspective, but also offer nimble, reasoned reflection in times of trouble. Analysts help Consuls work through personal problems rationally, and this can be great help when emotions are out of control.

Consul-Diplomat Friendships



Balanced Friendships with Diplomats

Compatible Souls

Consul-Diplomat friendships are often a quick fit, both sharing a sense of empathy that makes it easy to understand each other. While Consuls might find Diplomats' high-minded ideals a bit unrealistic at times, they love the sincere way they try to express them. Consuls find the way that Diplomats care about people and society to be inspiring. Being friends will likely help create balance for these two, as Consuls are exposed to a strong imagination, and Diplomats to practical thinking.

Social activities between these two are not always a guaranteed success though, as Diplomats tend to have dreamy, forward-looking visions of what might be that distract them from the present moment. Consuls, in turn, are looking for steady, reliable friend to stay by their side through thick and thin, happiness and pain – and they will do everything for such a friend when they find them. When spending time together, these friends' priorities and passions might be a little out of sync.

Fortunately, their hearts are usually in tune, as Diplomats are sensitive to their friends' needs and Consuls have only to express themselves to be heard in the most caring terms. If Diplomats lose their heads in the clouds occasionally, Consuls nonetheless find them to be extremely open and emotionally available, and these two don't take long to

establish a deep connection. Regardless of their personal preferences and ideal social settings, these friends find the warmth and cheerfulness of each other's company extremely satisfying, and have the potential to build an enduring friendship.

Discovering Support

Despite being bold, Consuls are not often adventurous by nature. However, the empathetic friendship of Diplomats is the perfect vessel for Consuls to try new things and broaden their understanding of life. Diplomats are unlikely to push Consuls into things they strongly disapprove of, being very attentive to their feelings. With that kind of support, balanced Consuls gladly challenge themselves to grow and learn, knowing that the more they experience in life, the more joy they will find.

The flip side is how stable and discerning balanced Consuls can be – they support Diplomat friends by sharing a realistic perspective and some helpful structure. Diplomats appreciate the way that Consuls forge a smooth path through life, and the focused, energetic compassion of Consuls is a lifeline to Diplomats who feel lost in chaos. Consuls help them bring a little order to their lives while also giving them all the kindness they need. When these friends each put their best foot forward, they balance idealism and practicality to notably improve each other's lives.

Unbalanced Friendships with Diplomats

Different Realities

Unfortunately, this friendship may experience friction as these types come to realize that their differing approaches or systems of belief are incompatible in certain situations. Consuls look to the past for tried-and-true examples of what works best, and Diplomats happily embrace revolutionary change. In unbalanced friendships, Diplomats may become frustrated with Consuls' insistence on social order and stability, rather than joining them in what they see as progress.

Consuls like to follow rules as an ideal, and in turn may become disturbed when they see Diplomat friends breaking rules *for* an ideal.

These two often feel as though they are living in different worlds. This really hits home when these types express opinions on what is or isn't fair. Consuls see fairness in practical rules being applied compassionately, whereas Diplomats like to create fairness through conditional approaches based on moral ideals.

Another difference is how Diplomats often embrace unrealistic dreams. Consuls eventually find this behavior tiring if those dreams always seem to potentials be on the horizon. This type wants to create a warm social structure around them, and can be baffled when Diplomats, especially Campaigners and Mediators, are always chasing something "out there" instead of joining them in the present. Frustration results if these friends cannot reconcile their very different approaches to life.

Upsetting Each Other

Watching a friend fall into things that seem imprudent or even perilous is frustrating for Consuls. Whether it's a dubious romantic interest, an implausible belief, or precarious financial habits, Diplomats' sometimes haphazard lifestyle worries characteristically grounded Consuls. They feel frustrated when trying to avert Diplomat friends' questionable decisions, even becoming openly critical, and their own rising emotions do little to foster a calm way out of the situation. When these two get out of balance and lose control of their feelings, things can get ugly, indeed.

Consuls in these situations can be relentless, often causing offense when they push corrective advice, no matter how true it is. To Diplomats, this can feel like someone stepping on their dreams or trying to control them, a common misinterpretation of even the best-intentioned criticism or correction. They are hurt by Consuls' firm rejection of fantastical possibilities, seeing it as a lack of support. Such conflicts threaten these friendships, as Consuls may remain persistently and vocally judgmental, and Diplomats may reject anyone who doesn't agree with them as fundamentally negative, even close friends.

Rebalancing Friendships with Diplomats

Understanding Perspectives

Resolving different perspectives within a Consul-Diplomat friendship

requires tapping into the positive emotions they feel toward one another. These friends don't need to agree on a lifestyle, but they can explain their heartfelt needs to each other. For Consuls, this may include conventional social interests, and for Diplomats, embracing new things. Either way, honesty and respect are key. Both these friends care about the other being happy, and if each must occasionally step out of their preferred modes to join the other in theirs, they can simply regard it as a gift to a friend.

Further, when these friends take the time to gently explain their different views on life instead of simply holding them up as "better," they will create understanding for each other. They can also show each other deep respect by asking questions with an open mind. It can be as simple as saying "That doesn't make sense to me, can we talk things over together so I can understand you better?" Consuls may be focused on stability and traditional social roles, and Diplomats more on progress and change, but the appreciation these two feel for the sincerity of each other's views brings them together. Agreement isn't required when enough genuine respect – and love – is present in a friendship.

Stepping In, and Stepping Back

Balanced Consuls are judicious about when to offer their advice and help, accepting that Diplomats are dreamers and must be allowed their dreams, but there are moments when a more grounded perspective is vital. It's not always easy to implement balanced intervention, but Consuls can work to maintain support while not becoming overbearing or judgmental.

If their advice is ignored, Consuls can respectfully retreat, making their ongoing willingness to help clear while holding true to their own perspective. They may have little choice but to accept an ongoing stream of questionable ideas and choices from Diplomat friends. If this happens, balanced Consuls take pragmatic solace in knowing that they tried to help. Avoiding participation in things they can't support helps Consuls maintain fair friendships with Diplomats, even if that requires stepping back now and then.

Consul-Sentinel Friendships

Balanced Friendships with Sentinels

Reassuring Steadiness

Other Sentinels are a good fit for Consuls, as both share an appreciation for dependability and practicality. These friendships support day-to-day activities and quality of life in general more than change, ambition, or curiosity. Consuls are reassured and buoyed by uncomplicated friendships with other Sentinels. Having someone steadfast and sensible in their lives is no small consideration for either of these types.

Consuls also find Sentinels' conventional social leanings appealing, whether such friends are Introverts or Extraverts. Their discussions revolve around grounded matters like work, current life events, and personal interests. Sentinels aren't big on esoteric topics, and consider those who constantly talk about broad, impersonal matters a bit baffling – they like to use the time to connect with each other. Among Sentinel friends, Consuls get a pleasant dose of real life rather than ideological grandstanding.

These friendships go beyond casual compatibility, though. When serious situations and major life events happen, Consuls also appreciate how Sentinel friends stand by their side with dedication. They offer the same in return, acting as strong, vocal supporters of the people who have earned their friendship. Consuls and Sentinels stand a very good chance of becoming each other's best friends for a lifetime.

Stability in Action

Favoring stable foundations doesn't mean that these friends don't care about progress. However, where Intuitive or Prospecting types

see a future teeming with endless possibilities, Consuls like everything moving firmly in a controlled direction. Having a Sentinel friend with an organized way of living and equally sensible goals helps both friends keep moving forward.

When difficulties arise in life, Consuls are often the first to step forward with a helping hand, and Sentinel friends respect and deeply appreciate their ready devotion. In turn, the judicious touch of a Sentinel friend is perfect for Consuls in times of trouble. Whether offering a thoughtful solution or simply some dutiful, hands-on help, these friends are cores of support for each other. This creates the security that they need to form a deep and grateful bond with each other.

Relatable Differences

Opposing personality traits may be easier for Consuls to relate to when displayed by fellow Sentinels. Executives' logic inspires Consuls to be more efficient, as it demonstrates creating useful structure through cool rationality. The quiet sensitivity of Defenders is charming to Consuls, who find their pragmatic, patient acceptance creates a gentle sense of connection. The reserved, thoughtful way that Logisticians work to create order impresses Consuls, who appreciate systems that work to the benefit of people.

Different Sentinel friends offer Consuls doorways to growth, broadening their view while staying soberly grounded alongside them. Shared values focusing on stability, tradition, and dedication make friendships within this Role a good way for Consuls to find supportive bonds as well as new ways of thinking. Commonality helps these friends see eye-to-eye while they learn from each other's differing approaches to life.

Unbalanced Friendships with Sentinels

Social Problems

While these types share many compatibilities, Consuls may find that other Sentinels have a hard time matching them socially, each in different ways. Consuls want to be immersed is a social framework, devoted to their friends and constantly involved in their lives. Some other Sentinels may not want this level of attachment. Introverted

Sentinels might not have enough energy to keep up with Consuls, becoming tired or stressed out by too much activity. Thinking Sentinels might not be able to offer enough emotional openness for Consuls to feel truly connected. When friends cannot give Consuls the level of engagement and company they seek, it can begin to feel unfulfilling to this type, creating distance.

The worst potential for Consuls might be when they become "frenemies" with someone of their own type. Consuls are bold, outgoing, and deeply concerned with their own status in the social order. It is easy for two such people to become competitive with each other, and when the relationship is unbalanced, this can be frightening. Consuls are forthright in expressing themselves, but they don't always speak their minds plainly. When balanced, this tendency results from wanting to be tactful and compassionate, but when it's unbalanced, Consuls may hide adversarial behavior under a veneer of guileful sweetness. Consuls engaged in a cold war of words can ruin an otherwise good friendship.

Mutual Immobility

Consuls and Sentinel friends build an enjoyable, predictable routine together, but unwillingness to try new things holds back their advancement on many fronts. Sentinels don't offer Consuls much inspiration to make even beneficial changes to their lives, such as moving or going back to school. These friends may even shut out other worthy people who bring changes that don't easily fit their social order. Instead of embracing the risks of ongoing development, these friends seek to reassure each other that things are OK.

Mutual reassurance provides a sense of comfort and solidity, but does little to motivate improvements. This isn't to say that these friends settle for failure, but they may settle for existing success. Even the most vigorous Consuls rarely see the value in spontaneously departing from a working routine. Consequently, these friends may not push each other to excel beyond the security of conventional accomplishments. They do each other a disservice if they don't occasionally step out of their routine together to see what life can offer, and what they are truly capable of.

Rebalancing Friendships with Sentinels

Adjusting to Needs

At the risk of sounding like a mattress ad, Consuls can rebalance many social problems with Sentinels by artfully conforming to their unique needs, and perhaps dialing things down a little. When Consuls are too firm in asserting themselves, they may create friction, but if they withdraw too far, they leave friends aching for their support.

When dealing with people with less tolerance for social contact, Consuls can respect their limits, using their own keen sense of emotional observation to determine when it's time to reduce the pressure. This doesn't necessarily mean detachment, but Introverts or Thinking Sentinels might appreciate doing something a little less actively engaged with other people, some of the time. For example, outdoor walks and time spent together in quieter pursuits give these types a chance to enjoy Consuls' company without needing to rise to their level of energetic social engagement with others.

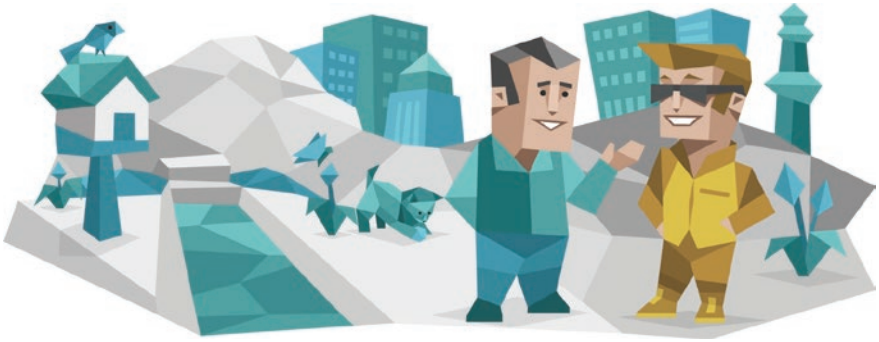
If Consuls find themselves feeling friction with other Consuls, they need only pause to remember the three things they admire most about the other person, and focus on the positive connection they have. Energetic types challenge each other, and some competitiveness can be quite healthy and fun, but the underlying connection must be one of mutual appreciation and respect. If jealousy creeps in, each person needs to take a hard look at why they feel a sense of threat rather than support. Communicating these feelings honestly gives Consuls a chance to set things right with each other.

Sensible Change

Sentinels excel at being responsible, so balanced Consuls and Sentinels alike keep an eye not just on each other's comfort and security, but on what will truly benefit each other long term. These friends wisely advise each other when they're in a rut, and offer ideas when change is needed to create success in life. When this requires embracing something new or unconventional, these friends can offer each other a judicious helping hand as well as supportive encouragement.

This applies to recreational pursuits as well as more serious matters, and these friends can set a goal of trying out three new things together each month. There's no need to leap off a cliff or take major risks, but sampling new fun with a trustworthy Sentinel friend leads to experiences that Consuls would not find on their own. This type is not reluctant to take on challenges, and can likewise boldly explore new adventures. Engaging the unknown together, at least occasionally, is a smart way for these friends to explore their own potential while sharing some fun.

Consul-Explorer Friendships



Balanced Friendships with Explorers

Zest for Life

Friendship with Explorers offers Consuls some notable opportunities. Explorers live for the moment and its pleasures rather than stability, and make for exciting friends. Explorers' ability to lose themselves in enthusiasm is a great counterpoint to Consuls' careful, methodical planning and sense of tradition. This friendship provides a fresh outlook that helps Consuls see a broader perspective on life, and serves their desire for active social engagement.

Consuls benefit from being led into fun and curiosity by an Explorer friend. Though it's not always easy, balanced Consuls practice relinquishing control and trying new things, especially in recreational matters where little is at stake. Developing adaptability without losing their cool is a very useful mode for this type. They can't always predict what life throws at them, and friendship with Explorers is a wonderful way to practice mastering the unexpected, the unpredictable, and the uninhibited aspects of life.

Offering Guidance

Balanced Consuls appreciate how Explorers' passion for discovery opens up a lot of fun and excitement for them both, but also see how such carefree enthusiasm can lead to unintended consequences. Supportive, hands-on advice is where Consuls shine in such a friendship. When they earn the trust of Explorer friends, they become a respected voice of sense. While not expecting Explorers to adopt more conventional views, they offer a warm, steadying hand with just the right amount of reserve to prevent calamity.

The other side of that coin is that Consuls who come to trust Explorer friends also accept a guiding hand to pull them out of their dutiful routine and explore something unknown to them. Consuls have a hard time embracing change, and Explorers provide not only help in this area, but inspiration and company when Consuls are ready to have some fun.

Surprising Capability

At first, Consuls assume that the more spontaneous style of Explorers, so different from their own planned approach, is not very effective. However, they are impressed when Explorer friends pursue things they care about to great success, overcoming challenges on the fly with adaptive tenacity. Explorers might change their minds frequently, but they throw themselves fully into mastering interests that are important to them.

When those interests align with Consuls' own, they find Explorer friends to be helpful, involved companions. Explorers add a little refreshing excitement to Consuls' projects and goals. For example, Adventurers' quiet curiosity introduces them to subtle experiences they might miss on their own. Thus type also very much appreciates the practical, hands-on side of Explorer friends. The intent way that Virtuosos hone their skills is impressive to Consuls, as it shows them the value of unconventional technical flexibility.

Motivation

Consuls enjoy the undaunted, open-minded spirit of Explorers, as well. The outward-focused vigor of Entrepreneur and Entertainer friends

matches their own energy, but with uninhibited enthusiasm. Consuls and Entertainers may get along especially well by sharing exciting recreational things together. What Explorers lack in steadiness, they make up for with zeal, approaching experiences and challenges with a flexibility that Consuls can learn a lot from.

In turn, Consuls' organized effectiveness impresses Explorer friends, especially when aimed at a common goal. Explorers grab for what they want, and as masters of energetic planning and engagement, Consuls help them ensure success. These friends lend each other very different kinds of help to move successfully through life. Consuls are utterly sensible, and their carefulness beautifully balances Explorers' lively adaptability. When these friends share a goal, each is impressed by what the other can do.

Unbalanced Friendships with Explorers

Dangerous Games

There is a dark side to living in the moment, as a lack of consistency and forethought often brings about wild disorganization, social friction, and financial instability. Explorers' uninhibited lifestyle and impetuous decisions challenge Consuls' boundaries of acceptance. Being exposed to too much chaos is deeply upsetting to this stable, emotionally connected type. It's not in their nature to abandon friends, but they are quick to share their concerns, unabashedly voicing criticism and advice alike.

Explorers in unbalanced friendships like this rarely understand or respect these doubts and reservations, either becoming offended by Consuls or losing patience and acting without them. Any idea of steadfast companionship can vanish into thin air when Explorers feel compelled to go in directions that Consuls refuse to consider. This mutual disregard causes both friends to question the friendship itself. Explorers resent the lack of support when they want to follow their hearts, and Consuls dig in their heels, wary of ever-changing, exuberant disorder.

Disappointment and Frustration

A seemingly minor area where the oft-fickle interests of Explorer friends can be very troubling for Consuls is planning. Consuls demand

organization, and Explorers don't exactly operate that way. Friends being late for, altering, or cancelling social engagements is deeply frustrating to Consuls. This type becomes overly critical when their own value of reliability is not reflected, and in turn, Explorers are dismayed by their intolerance.

More seriously, Consuls' reliance on emotions and human connections is challenged by Explorers, whose attention is easily pulled in new directions. It's hard for Consuls to understand why a good friend would put their energy elsewhere and fail to include them. In unbalanced friendships, even temporary social retreat by Explorers innocently following some other sudden interest may be misinterpreted by Consuls as heartless abandonment. Consuls rely on their connections for a sense of stability in their lives, and any loss of connection can feel very personal, even if not intended that way.

Disappointment goes both ways in this friendship, though: Consuls may offer little support or enthusiasm for engaging with the unknown to Explorers, who often see their insistence on stability and tradition as hampering adventure and discovery. Despite their social nature, Consuls may not turn out to be the excitingly fun friends that Explorers seek, and Explorers don't put up with disappointment for very long.

Rebalancing Friendships with Explorers

Respecting Limits

To achieve balance within this friendship, Consuls and Explorers need to consciously respect and accept their differences. These friends may test each other, but in this there is much opportunity for growth. However, both must recognize when it is time to stop wasting energy on silent – or vocal – judgment, and instead start talking about their needs gently, respectfully, and honestly with each other. Complaining isn't communication.

When Consuls fairly communicate their true limits, Explorer friends can avoid pulling them too far out of their comfort zone. A conventional outing together, perhaps a favorite restaurant, shopping, or a movie, is a good way for these friends to share some fun in comfortably

conventional environments. Explorers are all about indulgence and Consuls appreciate familiarity, so these friends are wise to share some common pleasures together.

Likewise, Consuls can stretch themselves when Explorers need company doing something unusual – Consuls rarely back down from a challenge. An easy way for Explorers to encourage Consuls to participate in less familiar activities is to involve them in the planning, and then make sure they stick to the plan. Consuls are a lot more willing to approach new things when the approach itself is well-organized and well-understood.

In any case, the importance of the friendship itself forms the common focus, with an understanding that sometimes compromises must be made for the sake of a worthy friend. Neither friend needs to lead in a direction they find uncomfortable, but they can try to follow, now and then. This kind of consideration is not automatic or easy for either Consuls or Explorers, but it is an area where both types greatly benefit from conscious improvement.

A Flexible Connection

There may also simply be times when these friends are wise to give each other some space. In this area, Consuls can learn from Explorer friends' tendency to be flexible. It may not be easy for Consuls to do, but pulling back and letting others live as they wish is a sign of tremendous respect, and true friends deserve that respect. When Explorers engage something too extreme for Consuls to support, they can practice respectful detachment. There's no shame in letting their friends be wild and free without them for a while – they can hear the stories and laugh together afterward.

Balanced Explorers appreciate this respect, and more than that, they make sure to affirm their bond by expressing that appreciation to Consuls warmly – something very important for them to hear. Balanced Explorers respect Consuls' limits, understanding that not everyone has as much excited curiosity in the face of the unknown, and also understand their need for closeness. When Consuls need to retreat to the familiar, balanced Explorers can make another friendly offer later or about something else less unusual.

For these friends, respectfully giving each other room to be themselves is necessary, and they can come back together later for something they both enjoy. Consuls can make Explorers feel valued by finding three things they admire about them, and then telling them so. Everyone loves compliments, and social niceties are Consuls' bread and butter. By making their own company warmly inviting instead of judgmental, Consuls keep Explorers coming back for more.

Conclusion

Mutual support and shared fun are among the greatest benefits of friendship, and are major priorities to a type as warm and social as Consuls, but for all their ability to connect, they still have limits. Friendship with people who expand those limits is an integral part of their journey into growth and happiness. This type knows the value of community, and finds that not only can they be wells of support for their friends, they can themselves be elevated.

Once they come to truly know people through friendship, Consuls' assumptions and beliefs are in for some challenges, but they are up for that challenge. Applying their judicious value of fairness and kindness is an excellent way for Consuls to benefit from friendships with people who think and act differently. This type is strong enough to maintain their values of reliability and trust while also benefiting from exposure to other lifestyles and perspectives through worthy friends.

Consuls naturally build a structure of good people around themselves, finding great satisfaction and a sense of continuity in giving and receiving social support. It is not difficult for this type to form fulfilling friendships, but finding balanced ways to respect friends' differences – or to become friends with those who seem very different – is an ongoing opportunity for this type to consider.

Parenthood

Caring

Consuls' warmth and care make parenting something that often comes naturally to them. Many people with this personality type feel like parenting is the task they were born to do. Often seen as ideal parents, Consuls' sensitive nature and innate desire to build meaningful connections allows them to connect deeply with their children. They are loving and affectionate, providing their children with both emotional and practical support throughout their lives.

From the start, Consuls' altruism is apparent in their parenting approach. They ensure a safe, stable environment filled with love, care, and support. Consuls' patience comes in handy as their children learn to become more independent, testing any limit they can find. While they expect their children to be respectful and well-behaved, their expectations are well-balanced with their understanding of their children's needs and behaviors. This combination of understanding and direction balances the affection and direction that allows children to truly thrive.

Responsible and Respectable

Consuls' mantra of "hard work, tradition, respect" is best exemplified in their relationships with their children. In many ways, they are the classic 50's era parental figure – strict guardians of family traditions who have no trouble when it comes to enforcing the rules and standards they've established, while also providing stable, pragmatic wisdom to a child who needs advice. Often seen as model citizens, Consuls expect their

children to carry that image, continuing the example they've set by being polite and respectful.

Consuls have a very responsibility-oriented view of life. They share a firm belief in the idea that one does what one can in order to contribute to the family and the community. This view is of course extended to their children. As soon as they are able, their children are expected to contribute in their own way, by cleaning their plates and their rooms and going to bed on time – by maintaining the order of things.

This type doesn't harbor wild, high-flying hopes of perfection for their children – Consuls are down-to-earth people and simply want to see their children develop into respected, responsible adults. But they also want their children to be decisive and capable, and that is something that can only happen when they have the chance to make their own decisions – and the chance to face the consequences of those decisions, good or bad – with the love and support of their parents.

While yielding control may be difficult, Balanced Consuls are able to exercise patience and restraint by allowing their children to fall off their bike, fail a test they didn't study for, or have their heart broken by unrequited young love. These youthful afflictions provide opportunities for parents to teach caution, resilience, and thoughtful problem-solving skills that will benefit their children for the rest of their lives.

Perfectionistic Expectations

Although they are generally understanding, Consuls have a tendency to set unrealistically high expectations for both themselves and their children. They expect that they will not just "meet their child's needs" but will excel at this by making sure that delicious and healthy food is on the table for every meal and the house is always spotless. Anything less than perfect can feel like a failure for Consuls, making them constantly feel like they are not "succeeding" as a parent.

Consuls often become uncomfortable when their children aren't constantly on their best behavior, especially in public. While they are generally understanding about their child's capabilities, they will always promote "proper" behavior through whatever means necessary. From carrying a disobedient toddler out of a store kicking and screaming to

chastising their teenager in the middle of a store, Consuls refuse to let their children "get away" with any behaviors they deem unacceptable.

Overly Controlling

With their desire to always do "what's best" for their children, Consuls can easily spiral into excessively controlling behavior. They are one of the most likely personality types to believe that their children should be guided in their education, and one of the least likely types to think that children need to be given freedom to develop. This system of beliefs can create a repressive environment, which prevents children from engaging their naturally curious instincts. Without the opportunity to freely explore their surroundings, pursue their interests, and make mistakes, children will never develop the ability to take initiative or bounce back from failures.

Controlling behavior has a tendency to present itself in negative ways, especially during stressful situations. Even small transgressions can seem like a personal affront to their authority, causing offended Consul parents to become disconcerted by their children. Discipline then becomes their primary tool for keeping their children in line and making sure that they follow the rules. Grounding their teen for a month after coming home 5 minutes late once (barring other more serious behaviors) is a drastic punishment for this particular transgression.

When parental discipline is focused entirely on punishing unacceptable behaviors, children lose out on the opportunity to truly learn from their mistakes. Constant criticism of their behavior, rather than providing alternative behaviors, often materializes in children as a sense of defeat. When children consistently feel this level of frustration, they may either become withdrawn or begin acting out – feeling that they may never be able to please their parents. Whether children *should* respond this way or not isn't relevant in this situation. The fact is, they will, and it's up to Consul parents to guide their development sensibly and according to the reality of the situation. Ignoring the facts doesn't help anyone.

Set Realistic Expectations

Consul's expectations are not always in line with what is realistic or even appropriate. Allowing their children to grow and build a separate

identity (while still encouraging proper behavior) is a fundamental part of both their own and their child's development. Each stage of their child's development requires adjustments in their expectations. This will be discussed in greater detail in the sections below.

The desire to feel needed is very strong for Consuls, and that desire is generally fulfilled throughout their child's early years. Unfortunately, as children get older and begin to exercise independence and develop their own sense of identity, they may reject some of the affection and input they had accepted from their parent so willingly in the past. While this can be a frustrating experience, Consuls benefit from adjusting their expectations and focus on discovering what new and equally important role they can play in their child's life.

Consuls may find themselves sacrificing many of their own needs and desires when they become parents. While this is necessary to a certain extent, it can leave them feeling lost and uncertain about their own identity when their children leave the nest. It is helpful for both Consul parents and their children when they model healthy personal development. Engaging in a hobby, participating in a spiritual practice, or taking a class to learn something new can provide satisfaction and growth while modeling ways to develop personal understanding to children who are attempting to find their own identity.

Create Learning Opportunities

When one's nature is focused on organization and structure, it is easy to become caught up in controlling behaviors. Children certainly need structure and benefit greatly from an organized household. However, excessive control of their environment can actually result in children who are unable to regulate their own behavior. Rather than focusing purely on controlling their child, Consuls can focus on providing them with opportunities to learn how to control themselves.

A toddler will certainly spill their milk the first time they try to make cereal by themselves. A parent who shows them how to clean up their spill and how to carefully pour milk to avoid spilling experiences less frustration than one who immediately puts their toddler in time-out. Not only are they teaching them a skill, they are preventing the inevitable meltdown that occurs when a toddler child feels they are

being unjustly punished. This technique takes more time up front, but saves a great deal of time in the future as their children become more competent and confident in their abilities.

If there's anything that Consul parents hope to accomplish, it's to raise children who are hardworking, capable, and responsible, just like they are. These lessons are best taught by intentional modeling, as opposed to the "Do as I say not as I do" mentality, and allowing children to learn through trial and error. Mistakes will be made, and should be looked at as an opportunity to create a teachable moment rather than something to be punished.

Parenting for Each Stage of Development

Each stage of a child's growth presents both unique challenges and exciting milestones. Learning how to navigate these stages can seem daunting, but the opportunity to build a healthy attachment and create meaningful memories makes it worth the struggle.

Renowned psychologist Erik Erikson proposed a theory of psychosocial development that identified eight stages, five of which take place between birth and 18 years of age. It's important to remember that these stages are not set in stone and the ages listed for each stage are approximate. Children develop at their own pace and meet each milestone in their own time. The following paragraphs will briefly discuss what to expect at each stage of development as well as how the strengths and weaknesses of the Consul personality type affect their parenting at each stage.

Building Bonds (Birth–1½ Years)

According to Erikson, the stages of infancy and early childhood last from birth until approximately 3 years of age. Children in these stages are very dependent on their parents to meet their needs. This is also when the bonds of attachment are created by meeting the child's needs, developing a trusting relationship, and promoting autonomy.

The first priority for infants in the journey to attachment is having their basic needs met. From being fed to receiving affection, infants will learn to either trust that their Consul parent will provide for them

or they will suffer from a sense of mistrust in all of their subsequent relationships. If parents are inconsistent in providing for their children or are especially violent or neglectful, an extreme situation to be sure, their infants will have difficulty creating a positive, trusting attachment with their parents.

Attentive and affectionate parents, especially those who engage in consistent physical contact such as snuggling or transporting their child in a baby carrier on their body, will develop trusting, hopeful relationships with their infant and are likely to have very little difficulty building comfortable attachments.

Balanced Infant Bonding

Building Reliable Bonds

Balanced Consuls excel at providing structure for their children and will certainly be able to meet their infant's needs in this regard. Reliability is key in building a relationship with infants, and Consul parents are likely to be very attentive to their infant by reliably feeding, changing, and comforting them when necessary. Most Consuls enjoy the infant stage, where their children rely on them completely for meeting their needs, and do not hesitate to provide for them consistently in a patient, caring way.

As parents, Consuls have an extreme sense of duty to meet their child's needs, which can motivate them when going through the extraordinarily draining infant stage. Where some parents may struggle with maintaining energy during this phase, thus creating mood swings or other inconsistent behaviors, Consuls not only survive this stage but even enjoy it. They have the ability to create a foundation for building trust and instilling hope in their infant.

Endless Energy

Infancy is an especially trying time for parents with the inevitable sleepless nights and exhaustion that are almost certainly guaranteed during this stage. Consul parents have an advantage in this regard as they are high-energy individuals, rarely tiring easily. This generous reserve of energy carries them through these especially exhausting days.

In addition to having the momentum needed to power through their sleep deprivation, Consuls' excess energy, if utilized effectively, can help to insulate them from some of issues that may be caused by exhaustion, such as feeling anxious, sad, or overwhelmed. While all new parents have these feelings to some extent (and if they are serious or continue for several days, they should be discussed with a medical professional), Consuls may actually thrive on the busyness and revel in the opportunity to make order out of the chaos.

Unbalanced Infant Bonding

Taking on Too Much

Although they are extraordinarily affectionate and attentive, Consul parents may have difficulty when they feel that they aren't appreciated. Consuls give tremendous energy to their family, friends, coworkers, and anyone else who seems in need of help. Adding a new child into the mix can quickly lead to burnout as well as feelings of resentment when they don't feel that their efforts are appreciated.

In addition to their obsession with helping others, Consuls are often hesitant to ever accept (let alone ask) for help, even when they truly need it. The infant and toddler years are undoubtedly some of the most challenging. The combination of high levels of stress and a lack of willingness to seek help from others – especially when a lack of feeling appreciated is added to the mix – greatly increases the likelihood that Consuls will suffer from burnout, frustration, resentment, and even depression.

Struggling with Expectations

In addition to struggling with taking on too much, Consuls may have unrealistic expectations of their children in this stage. They may believe that their infant should achieve certain milestones more quickly than is necessary or fret that their child isn't hitting milestones "on time." They may be more concerned about getting their child to sit up, roll over, feed themselves, or walk before they are truly ready, rather than appreciating their child's current abilities and engaging with them at their level.

While it is certainly exciting to see their baby roll over for the first time or sit up on their own, trying to push children to achieve these milestones early only causes frustration for both parties involved. Just because their infant isn't saying their first words at the same time as their friend's child doesn't mean that they are not on track developmentally. Development, especially at this stage, is not a measure of parental ability and both Consuls parents and their infants will be much happier and more relaxed if they are allowed to grow and develop at their own pace.

Rebalancing Infant Bonding

Determine Developmental Needs

At this stage, it is important to understand that developmental milestones are approximate and are not set in stone. Additionally, children who attain certain milestones earlier are not necessarily "advanced," and those who achieve them later are not always "delayed." A child who begins speaking at nine months old may be hailed as brilliant, while a sibling who doesn't speak until thirteen months is (incorrectly) assumed to be "behind" in development. Labeling a child as advanced or delayed, especially this early in life, can be detrimental to their development, as well as their self-esteem, as these labels often affect how others treat them.

A pediatrician or family physician is a parent's best resource for determining whether or not they should be concerned about their child's development. They can provide resources that cover what to expect at different stages regarding physical, intellectual, psychological, and behavioral development. Regular appointments with a physician will ensure that any issues are addressed as soon as possible, and this will help to put Consul parents' mind at ease.

Seek Support

Learning to balance their needs with their child's needs is one of the most important things that Consuls can do. Taking a thirty-minute bath while their partner is putting the kids to bed can help a busy Consul parent relax. Taking a relative up on their offer to babysit can provide the much-needed time to meet with friends for coffee. Even engaging

in a deep-breathing exercise for five minutes can help to clear their minds and relax their bodies. Talking to a friend or partner about their thoughts or feelings regularly can help Consuls parents both work through these feelings and spend time engaging in the relationships that are so important to them.

Additionally, learning to say no to others' requests when they don't have the time helps Consuls to find a more beneficial balance between helping others and meeting their own needs. If they are feeling unappreciated at home or overlooked by friends who may be "giving them space" to attend to their children, they should make an effort to voice these concerns. Reaching out to others and admitting vulnerability actually promotes bonding and increases understanding, which is exactly what sociable and sensitive Consul parents need.

Testing Boundaries (1½–3 Years)

Once they are mobile, young children become very interested in exploring their environment with their senses. Crawling, walking, grabbing items, putting things in their mouth, and verbal communication are just a few of the ways that toddlers learn about the world around them.

During this stage, Consul parents must provide a safe harbor for their children while still allowing them to experience and explore their surroundings. Children who are allowed to test boundaries yet still receive parental support and encouragement will develop a sense of autonomy. Children who are overly restricted, criticized, or made to feel guilty for their desire to test boundaries will ultimately experience a sense of shame and may suffer from feelings of incompetence or low self-worth. These feelings can last throughout their lives and may ultimately jeopardize their ability to achieve goals and develop positive character traits such as reliability or confidence.

Balanced Toddler Bonding

Supportive and Engaged

Extremely supportive, balanced Consuls make an ideal "home base" for their child during this stage as well. Their reliability and engagement

ensure that their child will never feel abandoned, ignored, or unloved. Even though children at this age are incredibly independent, they still crave (and need) a trustworthy caregiver, and Consuls do not disappoint.

Consuls' stamina and supportiveness are especially useful during the trying toddler years. While these years can certainly be challenging, balanced Consul parents enjoy promoting their child's curiosity and independence while still maintaining a safe environment. They take pleasure in helping their children learn how to pick out their own clothes and dress themselves and how to use and manipulate toys and tools (such as forks and spoons). As natural teachers, helping their children learn to become self-reliant and competent is one of Consul parents' greatest joys.

Provide Safe Boundaries

Although they prefer to run a tight ship, balanced Consuls excel at setting up reasonable boundaries that allow a toddler to feel as though they are unrestricted, but that feels controlled to the parent. The perception that they are allowed to play or explore freely is especially important for toddlers working to build a sense of autonomy. Something as simple as setting up a space where their toddler can color, glue, and paint without worrying about the mess or allowing them to pick out their own books at the library can feel incredibly liberating.

The toddler years are the first in which Consul parents need to fully utilize their natural ability to determine what boundaries their child needs and how to successfully create them. Providing a safe, structured environment gives Consuls the sense of control that they need to remain confident. When set up properly, this structure can expand and contract with their child's changing needs and abilities.

Unbalanced Toddler Bonding

Authority Issues

This stage can be especially challenging for Consul parents, as they may have difficulty accepting their child's desire to push boundaries. From insisting on dressing themselves (and putting their uncoordinated

clothing on backward) to refusing to eat any form of fresh produce (or any healthy food for that matter), toddlers often seem as though they are challenging their parents' authority at every turn.

Consul parents may be offended by a child who appears to challenge their authority or does not display expected behavior, especially in public. Hierarchies are to be respected, especially between parent and child, and when their authority is questioned or ignored Consul parents are likely to become frustrated. It doesn't help that their toddler will likely acquire a new favorite word, "No," that they will use forcefully and frequently. Consuls do not approve of being challenged and may find this stage of child development to be one of the most difficult to reconcile.

Constantly Intervening

On the other hand, Consuls thrive on feeling needed. In unbalanced situations, they can become completely focused on meeting their child's every need. In an attempt to "help" their child, Consuls may inadvertently raise a child who struggles with issues such as poor self-regulation and a lack of initiative. Constant interventions at the toddler stage can result in the expectation that everything will be done for them and can result in learned helplessness, or a sense of powerlessness that results in a lack of initiative.

Spoon-feeding a toddler who can use a spoon well enough on their own or dressing their toddler rather than letting them attempt to dress themselves because it's "easier this way" prevents children from gaining these important skills. Toddlerhood sets the stage for competence, and robbing them of the ability to gain these skills may prevent them from even attempting to develop their abilities in the future.

Rebalancing Toddler Bonding

Promote Responsible Independence

Pushing boundaries and defiant behavior are hallmarks of this stage and, while they can be extraordinarily frustrating, they are a necessary part of developing autonomy. Saying "no" is a way to establish boundaries, and developing boundaries is a fundamental component

to identity development. Consul parents who understand that their children are establishing autonomy and are not intentionally looking to usurp their authority will have more success in setting their own boundaries with their child.

Just because children are learning to set their own boundaries doesn't mean that parents should allow them to get away with demanding behavior. Rather, understanding *why* their children are engaging in this behavior can prevent some of Consuls' negative reactionary responses. For example, a Consul parent may become immediately upset by a toddler who yells "No" when they tell them it's time to leave the park. Rather demanding they leave without warning, the Consul parent can offer a countdown instead. "We're leaving in ten minutes. Five minutes left before we go! Ok, one minute left, finish up." This allows the child to complete any activities that they want and ensures that they understand their parent's expectations.

Focus on Long-Term Growth

Doing too much for their children can be just as damaging as inconsistent discipline, but with some of their own personal discipline, Consul parents can prevent or undo any negative consequences of their constant interventions. The most effective way to do this is by tapping into their natural desire for structure and an innate talent for organizing people.

Consul parents can encourage their toddler's development by regularly looking for opportunities to promote growth and autonomy. Letting a toddler pick out what they want to wear (from two or three options), letting them pour their own cereal, or allowing them to wash their own hands and face after mealtime (while feeling free to clean up anything they missed after) will not only give them a sense of autonomy but teach them practical skills as well.

Thirst for Knowledge (3–5 years)

The preschool years, from approximately 3 to 5 years of age, are a prime time for brain development and children at these stages accumulate knowledge at an extraordinary rate. Children absorb information like sponges through constant activity and a seemingly infinite range of

questions. Learning at this stage takes place through play, especially the unstructured kind, and lots of social interaction with family and peers. Creativity is also exercised extensively through imaginary play and make-believe games and stories.

In order to master this stage, children must be given the opportunity to not only make some of their own decisions but also be allowed to initiate activities, ask questions – and receive answers – and lead others in exploration play. Children who are not given these opportunities or are made to feel as though their constant questions or childish make-believe games are annoying experience feelings of guilt, frustration, and a lack of competence. Consequently, they may suffer from poor self-control or a lack of initiative.

Balanced Preschool Relationship

Natural Teachers

Balanced Consuls are both patient and strong-willed, which is helpful when parenting curious, active young children. They happily answer their preschool child's seemingly ceaseless stream of questions and take great pleasure in modeling practical skills, such as sweeping, picking up after themselves, or helping to fold laundry. Imparting their knowledge in a practical, useful way is one of Consul parents' greatest strengths.

Practical skills and academics are not the only topics that Consuls value – instilling a sense of character into their children from a young age is just as important to them as any set of skills. Consul parents teach their children to respect authority, from teachers to elderly neighbors. They insist on honesty, and are the type of parents who will encourage their preschooler to not only apologize to a neighbor who's flowers they dug up but also help them to replant those flowers. Consul parents feel it is their obligation as an upstanding citizen to instill these important principles through modeling and consistent reinforcement.

Promote Confidence

Consuls are generally confident in their interpersonal abilities, and rightly so as they are one of the most dedicated and outgoing types.

As a naturally social type, Consul parents actively encourage their own children to develop their own interpersonal skills. This is an incredibly helpful mindset to model and pass on to children, especially during the preschool and school years where they are increasing both confidence and competence.

For example, at this stage, they expect their children to interact well with other children and will work with them to use problem-solving skills to deal with any difficult-to-play-with children that they encounter ("Ask Jimmy if you can take turns pushing each other on the swing, then maybe he will let you have a turn as well"). If this approach doesn't work, they will provide additional guidance for their children to act upon ("Maybe you could see if Jimmy wants to play on the teeter-totter with you instead?"). If all else fails, balanced Consuls will teach their children how to withdraw from a situation or may intervene directly if necessary ("Jimmy still isn't playing with you nicely? Maybe you could see if Suzie wants to play with you on the slide instead?").

Unbalanced Preschool Relationship

Lacking Flexibility

Although they love promoting learning, Consuls may have difficulty following their children's lead during the preschool years. Consuls in this situation struggle with the spontaneous needs that children often present at especially inopportune times. As very schedule-driven, timely individuals, they are annoyed by preschoolers who are more interested in their coloring page than getting their shoes on when it's time to leave. Temper tantrums and bathroom emergencies derail the best laid plans and Consuls who focus on maintaining tight schedules frustrate both themselves and their preschoolers.

Unstructured play is another area that can bring out a Consul parent's lack of flexibility. Consuls may fall prey to the idea that free play is not as valuable as "educational" play or structured activities, and they may focus their energy on providing learning experiences rather than allowing their children to take the lead. Given their love of routine and structure, these parents may leave little room for their children to learn how to entertain themselves or make their own discoveries.

Exceptionally Overbearing

Consuls in unbalanced parenting situations tend to be a very dominant personality type, often attempting to control their child's behavior and schedule as much as possible. The tendency for Consul parents to be dominant and overbearing can be especially damaging to children who are Introverted and may struggle with forced social interaction. Extraverted Consuls may mistake an Introverted child's lack of desire to interact with peers at the park as a serious lack of social skills rather than a completely legitimate personality trait.

In reality, Introverted children are not any less socially competent, they are just more easily overwhelmed by external stimuli, such as a noisy, crowded park filled with strangers. Forcing them to frequently engage in overwhelming activities will likely lead to children engaging in temper tantrums or withdrawing into themselves and refusing to interact with others to an even greater degree.

Rebalancing Preschool Relationship

Increase Flexibility

Learning to gauge their children's developmental readiness can be difficult for Consuls who have become too focused on timely achievement. Rather than constantly worrying about their children's development, Consul parents can focus on allowing them to develop them organically. Children do not need an excessive number of play dates, "educational" toys and games, or structured learning periods throughout the day. Playing with simple toys allows them to engage their imagination, the key building block for developing their ability to gain knowledge as they grow.

One way that Consul parents can promote both learning and autonomy without being overly controlling is to allow their children to engage in free play without any agenda. Send them outside to play without any toys and watch as the space around them turns into an imaginary forest full of magical creatures. Provide toys that encourage creation rather than mere interaction, such as Legos, modeling clay, or wooden blocks. Allow children to play pretend with friends during a play date rather than planning a specific activity for them. Children who are allowed to

engage in free play at this stage will be much more likely to seek out learning experiences on their own throughout their life.

Understand Different Traits

While it is impossible to know a child's personality type before their brain has finished developing (which is usually around their mid-twenties) it is relatively easy to determine if a child is Introverted or Extraverted. Do they prefer to spend time alone over playing with others? Are they generally quiet or reserved? Answering yes to these questions could indicate that their child is an Introvert and therefore much less interested in constant social interaction or engaging in multiple group-based activities throughout the day.

Consul parents will be able to interact with an Introverted child more effectively when they understand that their behaviors aren't a result of poor social skills but, rather, a different way of processing their environment. For example, these children often prefer activities that focus on smaller groups such as swimming lesson as opposed to larger team sports like soccer.

They also need adequate time to recharge after social interactions such as birthday parties or play dates. Consuls who understand and accept their child's unique needs will, in turn, promote the confidence and compassion that their preschool child needs to truly thrive.

Creating Competence (5–12 years)

The early school years are an important period of skill development for young children. Not only are they still constantly absorbing new information, they are also working on becoming proficient in increasingly complex areas, from relationships to mathematics to athletics. Children who are both challenged and supported in these areas will flourish in both their abilities as well as their self-confidence.

If they do not receive consistent support, children at this stage can begin to feel inferior to their peers and are less likely to develop long-term goals or work toward achieving them. On the other hand, if they are not sufficiently challenged, children in this stage can begin to feel overly confident in themselves and their abilities and will lack modesty and compassion toward others.

Balanced School-Age Relationship

Supportive and Efficient

Striving to be effective students themselves, Consuls will encourage their child to develop efficient study habits, maintain good attendance, and engage in extracurricular activities or student groups. The school years, whether spent in a "traditional" educational environment or not, focus on the development of skills and obtaining proficiency in basic academics. Consul parents provide the necessary structure to help their children succeed, whether it is helping with homework, finding a tutor, or even just providing consistent support for a child who may be frustrated.

Consuls, while very supportive and encouraging of their children, balance these traits out very well with their focus on personal responsibility. They are no strangers to hard work themselves and encourage children of all levels and abilities to achieve their personal best. Consul parents are proud of their children's accomplishments, however, they loath arrogance and do not hesitate to call out children who are behaving this way. Being a good student is expected, and Consuls support their children in fulfilling that expectation.

Excellent Mentors

The school years are a time of intense learning, and Consuls are natural teachers who have no trouble modeling the skills needed for success in academics as well as real-world skills. Consul parents do not shy away from teaching their children the value of hard work and the importance of traits such as dependability and persistence.

Practical skills are just as important as academics, and Consuls take every opportunity to pass these skills on. In fact, these teaching moments may be one of the most meaningful ways that Consul parents spends time bonding with their child. Working on the car together, showing them how to make cookies, and teaching them how to do laundry are all fantastic opportunities to model skills and continue to build relationships with their children. Relationships are built on quality time spent together, and helping their children learn how to succeed in life is unequivocally high-quality time.

Unbalanced School-Age Relationship

Overly Concerned with Success

Consuls can become overly concerned about making sure that their children are truly "good kids," meaning that they are successful in school, socially connected, engaged in hobbies, and well-behaved. This mentality can prove especially detrimental to children in this stage by indicating that these markers are more important than holistic growth or their child's personal interests. From music programs to swimming lessons, Consul parents may place a great deal of emphasis on extracurricular activities that they believe will help their children be "successful," without appreciating that they are actually overburdening them.

Consuls parents who elevate their expectations to this extent may experience emotional outbursts from their children when they become fed up by an excessive focus on how they appear to others rather than how they feel. Less confident children may struggle to voice their frustration and, instead of rebelling, will become overly dependent on their parent's approval. This may result in difficulty setting their own goals and can lead to a struggle to achieve a healthy level of independence later in life.

Excessively Critical

Another area where Consul parents struggle is their emphasis on success over "learning how to learn." True learning is often a product of failure – which is a hard concept for many parents to grasp. A child who is struggling in math class but, through hard work and time with a tutor, manages to raise their grade from an F to a C, is learning. Parents who are overly focused on success, perhaps in the form of all A's on a report card, may not view their child's C as proof of learning, regardless of the great strides that they have made.

Consul parents can be quick to point out faults in their child's performance or behavior, rather than appreciating or acknowledging their children's strengths and achievements. They may think "They're already getting good grades in English, why should I worry about praising them for getting an A on their paper? It's expected." This can have a devastating effect on children who feel that their parent only

sees their faults and, as a result, they may become withdrawn or start acting out – believing that nothing they can do is good enough to please their overly critical parent anyway.

Rebalancing School-Age Relationship

Construct Values Together

As much as Consul parents may want their children to succeed in specific areas, it's more important that they focus on promoting their overall well-being. They are very devoted to their principles, especially responsibility, duty, and social involvement, as well as their children. Using their devotion, Consuls can create a definition of success that embraces a more holistic idea of what success truly means.

Consuls should encourage their children to develop their own principles and pursue their own definition of a successful life. This can be done by looking to the institutions that have played an important part in their lives, such as their faith, their family, or a club that they are involved in. It's important to let their child develop their own values rather than expecting them to emulate their parents. While a Consul's values may be noble, their child's sense of identity depends on their ability to determine their own values with the support and understanding of their parents.

Love Them Where They Are

Well-meaning Consuls place high expectations on their children hoping that this will encourage them to be successful. Unfortunately, when the focus is constantly on what is expected parents are apt to miss out on what their child has already achieved. What children need most from their parents is unconditional love and acceptance and Consul parents are more than capable of providing this for their children.

Consuls who are prone to fixating on mistakes or failures can turn this behavior around with one simple habit – a gratitude practice. It may sound simplistic but simply taking the time to intentionally find three things each day that they are grateful for is an incredibly effective way to stop the vicious cycle of criticism. Taking a few minutes each day to tell their child what they appreciate about them (I'm proud of you for

picking up your room without being asked; I am grateful that you are so passionate about drawing; And I am thankful that you passed your spelling test.) will ensure that children feel both loved and supported.

Find Thyself (12–18 years)

Adolescence is the transition from childhood to adulthood where adolescents focus on developing their own distinct sense of identity. This transitional period centers around the individual's sense of what their roles are in their relationships with themselves, others, and society in general. To determine their roles, adolescents in this stage begin the all-important process of identifying their personal values and beliefs. Educational and future career goals are made and relationships are developed based on how they align with these values and beliefs, making this a pivotal, foundational stage for the rest of their lives.

Balanced Adolescent Relationships

Promote Positive Principles

During this stage of identity development, adolescents need the support and understanding of their parents more than ever. Balanced Consuls parents encourage their adolescent child's growth by promoting positive principles, such as responsibility, integrity, and reliability, while providing them with freedom to explore these principles in their own way. As difficult as it can be, balanced Consuls understand the importance of assisting their children in the process of personal development and will do so to the best of their ability.

Regardless of the struggles that they may face during this tumultuous time, Consuls remain patient and steadfast in their devotion to their children. Their reliability, both in their affection toward their children and in the promotion of their positive principles, provides a solid foundation for Consul parents and their children. This foundation allows identity-seeking children to venture further into self-discovery while still feeling a sense of stability and love.

Honest and Dependable

Adolescence is a tumultuous stage for most children as they attempt

to determine who they are and who they want to be. These discoveries are often made through trial and error, which means that many mistakes will be made. Consul parents' dependability and honesty are indispensable during this stage, as they help their children cope with the many challenges they will face. Honesty is necessary to help them learn from their mistakes – an adolescent who skips class needs to know the potential consequences of this behavior before it's too late.

If Consul parents can develop an unbreakable trust with their adolescent by maintaining that same dependability and frank honesty when their adolescent comes to them with something truly serious – getting pregnant, getting suspended or expelled, or milder stuff like a rough breakup – they can establish themselves as a true source of stability and wisdom for life when their child needs it most. As chaotic and terrifying as some of these situations may seem, balanced Consuls can tap into their confidence and dependability and place their focus on those aspects of the situation that they have the ability to help with. They can treat the adolescent with respect, but balanced Consuls are still the wise, understanding adult in the room.

Unbalanced Adolescent Relationship

Overly Traditional

Consuls may have difficulty accepting certain aspects of their child's newfound identity during this stage. Their strong principles often coincide with a preference for "traditional," or familiar, roles, and a child who pushes the boundaries of these roles too dramatically could both shock and frustrate a Consul parent. Making sure that their child's values align with their personal and family principles can feel more important than their adolescent's desire to "find themselves."

Consuls' expectations of childhood are based on their past experiences, and societal changes that take place with each new generation can be both confusing and frustrating. Their adolescent children may appear almost unrecognizable as they attempt to determine if the principles and traditions that they were raised with truly represent who they hope to become. With their principles challenged, Consul parents may attempt to remove anything that appears to be negatively influencing

their child, from banning social media to prohibiting applying to certain colleges. These authoritarian restrictions are likely to result in eventual rebellion and potentially damaged relationships with their adolescent.

Difficulty Letting Go

The adolescent stage also requires that children become more independent from their parents, making critical life choices on their own and relying less on their parents for support. Consul parents can struggle with feelings of rejection if they believe that their child no longer needs them or desires their affection. Consuls who thrive on being their child's caretaker or identify primarily as a parent may take the loss of their control or influence in this role personally. This can result in overbearing or authoritative behaviors that may result in an attempt to prevent their children from becoming more fully independent.

Further, any criticism that they receive from their child, especially when it has to do with their deeply held principles, can be especially damaging to this people-pleasing type. Consuls who feel that their personal or family values are being criticized or rejected in any way tend to become very defensive. For example, an adolescent who decides that they no longer want to attend church services with their family will often result in a Consul believing that they have completely failed as a parent because their child is "rejecting" their values. They may react by engaging in passive-aggressive behaviors, attempting to subtly guilt or shame their child into behaving the way they want them to.

Rebalancing Adolescent Relationship

Model Personal Growth and Understanding

Understanding is key during this stage as their child's needs change and their independence grows with each year. This stage requires a constant rebalancing of responsibility and expectations as their adolescent child strives to becomes more capable, responsible, mature, and independent. It can be difficult for Consuls to decrease the amount of control they exert over their children – not necessarily because they view them as incapable but, rather, that they genuinely believe that they know best.

It's helpful for parents at this stage to encourage their children to develop their own personal values and, while they can draw from family values to do so, should be allowed to privately focus on embracing values that are meaningful to their individual journey. Most importantly, Consuls can take this opportunity to engage in some self-reflection as well, perhaps even taking time to discover a meaningful hobby, find a club or class to join, or become more involved in a community group or project. The self-discovery process doesn't end at adolescence, and Consuls who allow themselves to be inspired by their child's growth and development will improve their own as well.

Promote Healthy Independence

The adolescent stage requires that children become more independent from their parents, which is especially difficult for Consuls who thrive on being their child's caretaker or identify primarily as a parent. Rather than taking this desire for independence as a personal affront, Consul parents should learn to both celebrate and promote their adolescent child's development.

Practice encouraging children to take responsibility for their decisions and celebrate any progress they make toward becoming a self-sufficient adult. Finding new ways to engage at this stage that take advantage of their burgeoning skills is a wonderful way to bond. Allowing their child who has just received their license to drive them to the store in the "nice" car provides quality time with their child *and* time to practice this important skill. Parents who encourage their children's growth are much more likely to have meaningful bonds with them throughout their lives than those who look to promote dependence.

Conclusion

Parenting is one of the most challenging experiences that anyone will face, regardless of their personality type. Consuls have their own unique strengths and weaknesses that they need to leverage in order to build positive, proactive relationships with their children. There is tremendous potential for personal development that takes place when one becomes a parent, and Consuls can gain a much deeper understanding of themselves and others if they use this opportunity to do so.

That being said, the advice provided above is based on general growth stages for children and basic strengths and weaknesses that many Consuls share. Every child is different, and parents are the best judge of what their child needs. The advice above should be used in a way that works best for each family without adding additional stress, frustration, or burden. For special situations, such as behavioral or medical issues, it is best to consult with a professional pediatrician or pediatric psychologist to come up with a plan that works best for everyone involved.

Final Words

No personality type possesses a greater sense of real-world connection than Consuls. A desire to participate drives them in all areas of life, including in their relationships with friends, family, and romantic partners. When they gather their vast circle of loved ones, as they're often known to do, they offer unparalleled loyalty, dedication, and a dutiful sense of responsibility. Those close to Consuls know that they can always count on them, whether in need of gentle support or practical advice.

However, Consuls may spread themselves too thin if they focus all their energy on supporting their communities without giving back to themselves. People with this personality type may be sensitive to conflict and criticism, especially after they've given their all to a relationship. But rather than find fault in the behaviors or beliefs of others, they can learn to rebalance these cherished connections by adjusting their *own* approach.

In these pages, we've discussed how Consuls can enhance their romantic relationships, friendships, and relationships with their children. Of course, because relationships involve multiple people, no one person can "fix" them on their own – not even if that person is as dedicated as a Consul. Our hope is that, by drawing on the insights in these pages, Consuls can gain a better understanding of how to nurture their relationships without neglecting themselves. With kindness, grace, and respect for people's individual needs and truths, Consuls' firm outreach becomes the building blocks of a balanced, beautiful society.

So... What's Next?

You've reached the end of this book, but fear not – we've created many more resources for you. Here are a few that might capture your interest:

- Want more tests and insights to help you better understand and strengthen your relationships? Explore our Relationships Specialized Tests.
- Looking to enhance your academic or professional life? Check out the *Consul Guide to Careers*.
- Ready to build a strong foundation for your self-development? Our *Consul Guide to Personal Growth* may be just what you need.

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